
ARCANECHRONICLE

Snow Hero

S N S H e r o



Kadan & Arcane Echoes

40 EPISODES A COMPLETE EPIC

Snow Hero

SNSHero : Kadan & Arcane Echoes



A fantasy epic following Kadan, born beneath the blizzard, Celia, heir to the Wind Isle, and Ignis of the Flame Court through an age of war and deception.

This ebook is based on the SNSHero card universe and the newly adapted 40-episode Snow Hero web novel.

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PART I



Vows Beneath the Blizzard

Two Vows Beneath the Blizzard



Winter arrived first in Elwin village, at the southern end of the Kingdom of Lighthaven. The snow covered the castle walls starting during the day, and as the sun set, it even engulfed the boundaries of the roads and roofs. People lined their windows with thick parchment and turned off their lights early. It was because of the rumor that the Shadow Realm cavalry that had taken over the north had crossed the border.

That night, Aleksandar and Balian were sitting across from each other in the small tavern behind the blacksmith shop. Aleksandar was a quiet hunter who used dual swords, and Balian was a man who pierced the eyes of a wolf in a blizzard with an arcane spear. The two men lived by plowing fields and pounding iron, hiding the fact that they were descendants of the fallen Holy Knights. The only hope that could endure the night of a defeated nation was that their wives would soon give birth to children.

When the door opened, the smell of blood came in before the wind. Hercul, wearing tattered pilgrimage clothes, stood at the threshold. The broken seal of the Holy Knights was hanging on his waist, and the golden mana leaking through his gloves drew a thin pattern on the wet floor.

The tip of Balian's spear touched his neck. Aleksandar's sword was already blocking the escape route behind his back.

If you are a hunting dog from the Shadow Realm, it would be a waste of time to reveal your name.

Hercul spread his palms instead of answering. The two men's weapons stopped as if they had hit an invisible wall. As the golden protective shield surrounded

the tavern, the liquor bottles on the shelves cried all at once. But he didn't fight back. He simply placed the belongings of the executed Holy Knight Commander Ake on the table.

After the misunderstanding was resolved, the three discussed the state of the kingdom until dawn. The royal family hung on to banquets and tax books, and border towns took it upon themselves to keep monsters and marauders at bay. Hercul was chasing a list of court nobles who had connections with the Shadow Realm. At the top of the list was Death Knight Artus, Regent of the Court of Red Glass.

Before leaving, Hercul took out two silver daggers. Inside the handle, an unnamed rune was still sleeping.

Give each child one when they are born. This does not mean that they should pass on their parents' grudges. It means that they do not forget the truth until they decide for themselves who is their friend and who is their enemy.

Aleksandar said he would give his son the name Kadan, which means a shield that endures to the end in an old northern language. Balian said he would call the child Ignis to mean not to get lost even in the fire. Instead of alcohol, the three men filled their glasses with melted snow and prayed for the safety of their two unborn children.

A few days later, on a snow-covered road, young nobleman Lucian met Aleksandar's wife, Elwin. He was dressed like an injured traveler, but hidden within his cloak was the coat of arms of the Red Glass Court. A bowl of warm soup and a few kind words from Elwin awakened Lucian's desire. He turned the entire town into a den of traitors to take her over.

At dawn, soldiers in black armor surrounded the village. Aleksandar sent his wife out to the north canal and stood on the bridge alone. Balian lifted his spear after putting his pregnant wife, Ysela, in the carriage. The two tore through the siege dozens of times, but the enemy even used the local residents as shields.

Aleksandar chose the line where the resident was standing and struck the soldier's wrist with the back of his sword. The wounds on my shoulders and thighs increased as I was doing things that would have been quick to cut. Balian lifted up the fallen soldier's spear and threw it at the residents. The baker and carpenter, who had never held a weapon in their lives, stood on the railing of the bridge, sending their family behind them.

Lucian looked down on the battle from high above. He shouted to Aleksandar that he would guarantee Elwin's life if he admitted to treason. Instead of answering, Aleksandar cut one of the ropes on the bridge. The wooden board the soldiers were standing on tilted and fell into the icy water.

Your wife's life is not guaranteed by your words.

Balian's carriage was intercepted by the court cavalry at the end of the alley. Ysela crawled under the carriage, covering its stomach, but Lucian personally grabbed the reins and stopped it. She grabbed some mud and threw it in his face. Because of that short resistance, Balian thought his wife had run away and lured the enemy towards the cliff.

Aleksandar did not back down from the bridge until the end. By the time his sword broke, Elwin had already disappeared beyond the blizzard. Balian fell into the rapids at the bottom of the cliff while trying to protect Ysela, and Lucian kidnapped Ysela in the confusion and took him to the palace.

Arriving in the northern wilderness, Elwin kneeled toward the burned village. The dagger in my arms trembled slightly. A child who had not yet come into the world kicked his foot from the inside.

The refugees who followed late could not say that Aleksandar was dead. Elwin didn't even ask. He put the broken sword sheath that someone had given him into his bosom, and buried the wheat seeds he had brought from the village under his eyes. Even if I couldn't come back, I hoped that someone would be able to eat bread again on the spot.

You were not born for revenge.

Elwin wiped his tears and walked again.

Just be someone who doesn't bow your head in the face of lies.

Oath of the Seven Pursuers



When Hercul arrived at the ruins of Elwin village, all that remained were blackened rafters and blood stains on the bridge. He found Aleksandar's broken sword in the snow. The blade had jagged marks that were not found on the official weapons of the Shadow Realm. It was evidence that someone inside the kingdom had designed the attack.

Hercul followed the traces into the Seven Bridges of the southern port and ran into seven unexpected people. Blacksmith Grimli, Crossbowman Aila the Demon Hunter, Apothecary Eliana, Blind Stalker Gawain, Gambler Kaze, Boatman Rondol, Acrobat Robinyard. They came from different backgrounds and had different accents, and were an unofficial rescue team that took in war orphans.

The first meeting wasn't good. Hercul believed the report that they were kidnappers, and the seven saw him dressed as a paladin as a stooge of the court. The market's tent was torn apart and boxes of fish flew through the air. Every time Grimli's hammer hit the guard, golden ripples spread to the bell tower.

Gawain could not hear Hercul's footsteps, but there was no time to stop his colleagues. Kaze scattered seven coins from his pocket to find weak spots in the protective formation, while Aila the Demon Hunter selected only the coins that bounced and shot them with his crossbow. Hercul blocked the arrows and turned the angle of his shield to prevent shrapnel from hitting the people in the market.

Rondol raised the water from the canal and tied Hercul's feet. As he tried to evaporate the water with golden mana, Eliana mixed the herb powder. The hot herbal steam stung my eyes. As the legendary paladin coughed and collapsed

on a pile of fish, Robinyard couldn't help but laugh even during the fight.

It was only one child who stopped the fight. The child hiding behind Aila the Demon Hunter's back grabbed the hem of Hercul's clothes and said.

Those people didn't sell us, they saved us from being sold.

Hercul put down his mace. The seven also put up their weapons, but only Grimli snorted instead of apologizing. The ledger of the human trafficking ship they were chasing also had the signature of Lucian. It was like discovering the same enemy on different paths.

The night he was checking the ledgers in the port warehouse, Robinyard threw seven liquor jars onto the roof. The jar did not break, but stopped in the air and spun in a circle. It was not alcohol, but a floating compass that revealed the mana route of the smuggling ship. Each time the blue liquid tilted, a new ray of light appeared on the floor map.

In the ledger, instead of the children's names, their height, weight, and mana attributes were written down. Eliana rewrote the name of each rescued child next to it. Hercul also silently picked up the pen. They have been working for a while to return the calculation sheet to human records.

One line headed to the northern Wildlands, and the other line headed to the Red Glass Court. Hercul noticed that Elwin and Ysela were pulled in opposite directions. The two unborn children were also probably somewhere along the way.

I am going to the palace. Hercul said. You guys take charge of the north.

Grimli crossed his arms. Why should we keep your promise instead?

Hercul took out Aleksandar's broken sword and a silver dagger to give to the child. It's not because it's a request from a dead person. It's because we can't just leave a world where living children inherit their parents' crimes.

Gawain heard the vibration of the dagger with his invisible eyes. A faint but clear resonance of life was answering from the north. He was the first to nod. The remaining six also grumbled or sighed and agreed in their own way.

That day, the seven pursuers gathered at the top of the bell tower and made a promise. Whoever finds the child first takes him as his disciple and teaches him the power to protect himself. Eighteen years later, the two children meet under the bell of Seven Bridges, truly ending the tragedy of their parents' generation.

Opinions were divided on how to record promises. Grimli was intended to be engraved on a steel plate, and Kaze was to be left as a password so as not to be discovered by the enemy. Robinyard stamped the handprints of seven people on the inside of the bell. It was a way to ensure that even if one person changed their mind, the others would remember.

Hercul added one condition. Don't make them each other's enemies. You can make them compete to see who is stronger, but you shouldn't make them compete to see who they hate more.

Before the words were finished, a black arrow pierced the roof of the warehouse. They were court assassins who sensed their pursuit. The seven jars shattered at the same time, spreading a blue curtain, and Hercul's protective guard covered it. The eight men fought their first joint battle, back to back.

At dawn, Hercul departed south. The seven pursuers headed toward the northern gateway. On the snow, eight different types of footprints continued side by side for a moment, then split into two.

Blood on the Mist Cliff



The seven pursuers heading north got lost at Mistfall Cliffs. Even though it was midday, the fog had risen from my ankles to my shoulders, and there were unfamiliar handprints on each rock. When Eliana dropped the medicine on the handprint, silver powder arose. It was a trace of a forbidden art that took mana out of the body and hardened it like a corpse.

That night, two people appeared at the abandoned temple on the cliff. Medusa Gorgo was blindfolded and moved by sound, while Belphegor had black crystal armor covering its skin. They were once students learning runes from the Wind Sage Aeolus, but after stealing part of the Nine Shadows Codex from their teacher's temple, they were using people's life force as experimental material.

Gawain tapped the floor three times with the iron staff. There were eight echoes that returned, but there were seven in their group.

It s the ceiling!

Belphegor fell and split the temple floor. Grimli caught it with his hammer, and Aila the Demon Hunter's crossbow pierced the fog. However, Medusa Gorgo first heard the vibration of the arrow flying and twisted its body. Black threads stretched from the tips of her fingernails, sewing Robinyard's shadow to the wall.

Although each of the seven men was outstanding, it had not been long since they fought together. The knife thrown by Kaze got caught in Rondol's oar, and Grimli's hammer wind blocked Aila the Demon Hunter's vision. Medusa Gorgo did not miss the opportunity. The poisonous fog spread and one by one they

fell to their knees.

The first to stand up again was Robinyard, who was usually the quietest. He cut off his own shadow with a sword and blocked Medusa Gorgo's path. Belphegor's crystal arm pierced his chest, but Robinyard held on to his enemy with both arms even as he fell.

Now. This time, let s look at each other and move.

Based on the sound of Gawain's staff, Aila the Demon Hunter took three steps and shot an arrow to the left. Kaze deflected the arrow with his blade, and Rondol's wave rune doubled its speed. The moment Grimli's hammer broke Belphegor's armor, Eliana's purifying agent seeped into the crack.

As Belphegor's crystal melted, the names of the people engraved within it were revealed. There was evidence that the life force stolen through the experiment had been used as armor material. Eliana couldn't pour more purifier and his hands were shaking. Belphegor saw that expression and for the first time looked at his arm like it was a monster.

Medusa Gorgo and Belphegor took the codex pieces and fled beneath the fog. They were able to give chase, but the seven people stayed by Robinyard. Every time he breathed, small bubbles of blood formed around his mouth.

Tell me when you find the child. The world needed at least one fool who wouldn t run away.

As the dawn bell rang in the distance, Robinyard's hands grew cold. The six people did not build a grave on the cliff. This is because the prohibitionists were able to find the body. Instead, he melted his acrobatic silver bells and attached them little by little to each of his six weapons.

Grimli broke the handle of the hammer while chopping firewood to cremate the body. Aila the Demon Hunter did not put down a single arrow until the funeral lights were extinguished. Kaze, who always changed the mood with words, couldn't tell any jokes. For the first time, the seven people realized how

big the silence was for the six of them.

Eliana divided the ashes into seven small glass bottles. Each of the six people took one bottle and decided to give the last bottle to Kadan. It was not to impose a debt on the child he had not yet met for his dead teacher, but to let him know that there was someone waiting for him.

Returning to Seven Bridges, they rented the highest floor of the separate bell tower. It was a meeting place eighteen years later. There were seven glasses on the table, but no one touched one.

Grimli wrote a letter to Hercul. I found Kadan's life resonance in the north, and I will definitely bring him back to teach him. The writing was poor and the ink was smeared here and there, but the last sentence was straight.

We lost one person. Therefore, I will teach my child how to survive and protect before how to kill.

The morning sun rising outside the bell tower illuminated the seven cups one after another. The sound of silver bells was heard even in the empty drinking glass.

The Child Raised in the Wastes



Six years have passed. Elwin raised his son among the tents of Wildland nomads. The child was strong, but he spoke late and could not properly light a spark of mana. While his peers had fire and wind at their fingertips, Kadan carried buckets and mended fences.

People called him Kadan. This was the name Aleksandar chose before he died. Kadan thought that who called him was more important than the meaning of his name.

One day, Gilgamesh, a boy in the wilderness, was surrounded by assassins from a hostile tribe. Kadan jumped into the snow without a hunting bow. He threw a chunk of ice to blind the horse and ran towards the frozen river, carrying the fallen Gilgamesh on his back. The thin ice cracked, but he spread his weight and crawled out.

Even after arriving across the river, Gilgamesh could not speak for a while. He couldn't understand why the child he saw for the first time had fallen into the ice water. Kadan took off his wet boots and stood by the fire, saying that if he had been alone, he would have wanted someone to come.

You could still die.

That s why you re alive.

Gilgamesh never forgot that simple answer for the rest of his life.

Gilgamesh's father, Fenrir, was a war leader who attempted to unite the various tribes of the Wildlands. He offered to give him gold or horses in return for saving his son, but Kadan only asked for leather to fix the roof of Elwin's tent.

Fenrir laughed out loud and sat Kadan down at the family table.

There, Kadan made a brotherly pledge with Gilgamesh and also became close to Fenrir's daughter, Titania. Titania shot a bow better than Kadan and was more outspoken. Every time she smiled, her long red hairband blew in the wind.

Titania taught letters to Kadan. Kadan missed the middle stroke every time he wrote his name, and Titania made him rewrite it dozens of times with a stick over his eyes. It was because of that winter that Kadan later kept his first name tag, which he wrote clumsily, for a long time.

Are you going to go south when you grow up?

My mother told me to find the truth.

Then promise to return. Anyone who only promises to leave is a coward.

Kadan tied the red string she held out to her wrist. At the time, I didn't know how long a promise could hold a person's heart.

Meanwhile, the six pursuers had been wandering the Wildlands for six years. Without knowing the child's name or face, I followed only the faint resonance of the silver dagger. One night, Gawain heard the sound of metal crying on a distant rocky mountain. Kadan was pulling out a wolf cub trapped in the ice with his father's dagger.

Grimli tested the child as soon as he saw him. He suddenly swung the hammer and broke the ice under his feet. Instead of rushing towards the attacker, Kadan first pushed two nearby children to safety. Even though he fell into the water up to his waist, he did not let go of his dagger.

Elwin did not believe the six people who suddenly appeared. Even after checking the glass bottle containing Robinyard's ashes and Aleksandar's broken sword, he did not hand over his son. Every day, Gawain sat outside the tent and tapped his cane to Aleksandar's favorite song. A week later, Elwin

opened the door first and served warm tea.

You're slow, you're dull, and you don't even know the basics of fighting. Grimli said.

Gawain smiled faintly. Still, he's the kid we were looking for.

The joy of reunion did not last long. That night, in the cave where Kadan went to draw water, he heard a person's moaning. Inside, Belphegor was lying in chains. When he saw his pursuers, he laughed and held out his hand to Kadan as if he had been waiting for a long time.

Aren't you curious about the face of the person who killed your father?

Kadan drew the dagger but did not stab. Medusa Gorgo's fingernails flashed in the darkness behind Belphegor's back. The chase, which had not ended for six years, was now catching up with the child's life.

Phantom in the Downpour



The chains in the cave were a trap. The moment Kadan approached Belphegor, the runes on the ceiling flipped over and black fog poured out. Medusa Gorgo avoided Kadan's eyes and burrowed into his shadow. Just before the cold nails touched the nape of the neck, Gawain's cane split the floor.

Don't believe your eyes, Kadan. That woman is not where you look.

Kadan closed his eyes. I heard the stone dust falling like raindrops, Grimli's heavy breathing, and the direction in which the chain was being dragged. And then he swung the dagger at an empty spot that made no sound. The tip of the knife tore Medusa Gorgo's sleeve.

The six teachers spread out their formation without any time to be surprised. Aila the Demon Hunter's arrows blocked the retreat, and Rondol raised groundwater to wash away the fog. Kaze wrapped Belphegor's chain around the pillar. Eliana extracted the poison that had begun to spread on Kadan's neck using a crystal syringe instead of a silver needle.

Belphegor broke the restraints and rushed at Kadan. When Grimli's hammer and crystal arm collided, the cave wall collapsed. Medusa Gorgo turned to save her lover, and at that moment, Gawain broke her hearing rune.

Kadan aimed a dagger at the chest of the fallen Belphegor. He might have been connected to the attacker who killed his father. It seemed like if I put my hand down just once, some of my long-standing questions would end in blood.

However, an old necklace could be seen between Belphegor's armor. Inside was a small welcome stone with two people smiling with their teacher Aeolus.

It was proof that the monster was not a monster from the beginning. Medusa Gorgo did not miss Kadan's hesitation. She disappeared down the collapsed chasm, dragging Belphegor with her.

In the welcome stone, Medusa Gorgo's eyes were not covered, and Belphegor's arms were also human. Between the two, young Celia was throwing flower petals and laughing. Kadan couldn't look at those faces for long. The fact that a past unknown to oneself was still alive in the enemy's body was more difficult to handle than the sword.

Grimli was furious. If you let the enemy live and you die, who will remember that mercy?

Kadan could not answer. I couldn't tell whether it was mercy or fear. Gawain did not give him the correct answer. However, he said not to forget the weight of choice.

The cave collapsed and even the snow layer of the mountain cracked. Outside, unseasonable rain fell. The group was scattered by the rapids, and Kadan clung alone to a crevice in the rocks. As his fingers slipped one by one, someone grabbed his wrist.

Above the rapids, the six teachers were also looking for each other. Gawain distinguished the trembling of silver bells in the sound of water and pinpointed the locations of his colleagues. Rondol diverted the water and Grimli turned a fallen pine tree into a bridge. The cooperation they were trying to teach Kadan first saved their lives that day.

It was Belphegor. He was hugging Medusa Gorgo with his other hand.

No debt left behind. He threw Kadan onto the rock. Next time we meet, don't hesitate.

The torrent swallowed the two people. Kadan tried to run after him, but Grimli grabbed his waist. On the black water, Medusa Gorgo's silver hair appeared for a moment and then disappeared.

After the heavy rain stopped, the six teachers decided to teach Kadan their respective techniques. Before, they thought the child was too dull, but he was faster than anyone else in terms of reading sounds and looking out for others in times of danger. Gawain was in charge of how to listen to the terrain, Aila the Demon Hunter was in charge of how to wait, and Grimli was in charge of how to shock.

Unlike the heroic story, the training was boring. Kadan guessed the sound of falling stones all day, and the next day he walked up and down the hill without spilling a bowl of water. Every time you make a mistake, Kaze counts again from the beginning. Kadan was surprised that it took longer to mop the floor and maintain equipment than to swing a sword.

Eliana treated his hands every night. There is a difference between enduring a wound and neglecting a wound. Kadan learned to apply that phrase to the mind rather than the body much later.

Kadan buried a small piece of crystal that fell from Belphegor's necklace at the entrance of the collapsed cave. Because they could not decide whether they were enemies or benefactors, no graves or monuments were built.

That night, for the first time, he awakened Rune from his father's dagger. A speck of frost bloomed on the blade. Although it was small and imperfect, it was a snowflake that did not melt even in heavy rain.

The Art of Breathing Stars



The teachings of the six teachers pulled Kadan in a different direction every day. Grimli told me to hold on like a rock, and Kaze told me to cheat before the wind. Aila the Demon Hunter told me to stop breathing, but Rondol told me to let my breath flow like a wave. Kadan didn't want to throw anything away, so he messed up all his moves.

Even when he was fifteen, he could not complete the simplest continuous fasting. The teachers were even more frustrated because they knew how sincere the child was. The day Grimli got angry and turned away, Kadan climbed the ice cliff alone all night long.

There was a Griffon nest on the cliffside. Two cubs that had lost their mother were crying from starvation, but the height was beyond the reach of a wingless person. Malfuon, wearing a moss-colored coat, watched from below as Kadan tied the rope and fell several times.

If you climb with just your arm strength, the cliff will push you away.

Can a cliff push a person off?

If you can't hear the world breathing, there's no need for the world to listen to your circumstances.

Malfuon walked up the cliff without lifting a finger. Wherever I put my feet, moss bloomed and clung to the slippery ice. After coming down with the baby Griffon in his arms, he told Kadan to come to the summit three days later when the full moon rises. The condition was not to tell anyone.

For three days, Kadan only practiced rope knots. It was not because he wanted to avoid being caught sneaking out every night, but because he wanted to avoid the shame of falling off a cliff and being rescued by his teachers. However, on the first climb, the knot came loose and I slipped for about ten meters. As he removed the ice cube from his palm, he learned the obvious truth that death hurts more than shame.

Kadan was concerned about deceiving his teachers. However, it seemed like if he continued to stay in his place, his sacrifice would be in vain. He spent half the night climbing to the top. My palms were busted and my knees were ground on ice, but I arrived before the moon set.

Malfuon did not raise his sword. He made Kadan sit down and reminded him of a star above his head with each inhalation and a snowflake beneath his feet with each exhalation. He explained that mana is not a fuel to be grasped by muscles, but rather a matter of matching the beat between the body and the world.

Nothing happened in the first month. In the second month, when Kadan exhaled, the eye dust formed a circle. Six months later, the ice under my feet did not break while climbing the cliff. Kadan realized that the techniques of the six teachers were not contradictory, but had different beats.

Malfuon never once praised me for doing a good job. When he was out of breath, he threw a small tree nut at Kadan's forehead, and when he was too focused, he deliberately asked the wrong questions. If you can't hear the footsteps of the person next to you because you're counting the stars, who is that practice for? Kadan then realized that silence should not be a cave to forget about the surroundings.

Gawain was the first to notice the change. This is because the sound of Kadan's footsteps disappeared and his breathing became deeper. He didn't ask me where I went every night. Instead, he only said, If you try to show off your newfound strength by hiding it from us, I will break your legs.

The moment the teachers and Malfuon's teachings met, Kadan's sword changed. The weight learned from Grimli was hidden in Kaze's deception, and the stoppage of Aila the Demon Hunter led to the flow of Rondol. He didn't feel out of breath even after completing his first consecutive fasting.

Grimli kicked Kadan's ankles to hide his admiration. Even though Kadan fell, he did not let go of his sword and even struck down the wooden arrow thrown by Aila the Demon Hunter. The six teachers told him to reveal the existence of Malfuon only then. Kadan first apologized for lying and then showed everything he had learned at the top.

Gawain did not go to Malfuon to duel. Instead, I left a bottle of alcohol on the top of the cliff. The next day, next to the empty bottle, there was a letter written on a leaf saying, I like that you didn't try to monopolize the child.

At that time, Hercul's messenger crystal arrived in the Wildlands. It was news that Balian's son was alive and would be raised as a prince in the Red Glass Court. The name is Ignis. The day of the promise the two fathers made eighteen years ago was also approaching.

Elwin handed her husband's dagger and the truth to her son. Even if you find the person who killed your father, before your anger speaks, ask him why he made the choice he did.

Kadan decided to leave for the south. At the bottom of the cliff, Titania was waiting for the two tamed Griffon. The cubs that Malfuon rescued had already grown to the point where they could carry a person.

Find your way back in the sky. Titania tied the old red string back to Kadan's dagger handle. And even if you see the stars in the south, don't forget the stars in the north.

The Traitors Camp



On the last night before leaving, Kadan followed Medusa Gorgo's traces with Malfuon. She was practicing the forbidden runes of the Nine Shadows Codex in an abandoned mine near Fenrir's camp. Every time the silver chain whip wrapped around the rock, the mana in the stone dried up.

The two people who followed Medusa Gorgo discovered a bigger conspiracy. Fenrir's sworn brother, Barghest, was secretly meeting with Lucian, an emissary of the Red Glass Court. They planned to lure Fenrir to the conference hall, kill him, and hand over the Wildlands' tribes to the Shadow Realm.

Kadan ran straight to the camp. However, Fenrir only believed the words of the young warrior and could not doubt his old sworn brother. Rather, Malfuon, who came with him, was framed and bound as a spy for the palace. Barghest's troops had already surrounded the camp in layers.

Fenrir asked Kadan for evidence. Kadan repeated the conversation he heard in the tent, but people laughed at him, asking if his memory was evidence. Malfuon was tied up and said nothing. I wanted to see if Kadan would explain his own observation to the end, rather than relying on someone else's authority.

The clue was in the boots of the murdered messenger. It wasn't Wildland dirt, but red glass dust. Titania found the same powder in the saddle of envoy Barghest. Fenrir then ordered alert, but it was already too late.

As the sun set, Barghest climbed the hill alone. He returned the canine necklace he had exchanged with Fenrir long ago and encouraged him to surrender.

We just have to live within the boundaries set by our ancestors. Why do you want to unite all the tribes?

Fenrir buried the necklace in the ground. We want to end children dying in the same well every year. If tradition is an excuse to increase the number of graves, we need to change it.

The attack began at dawn. Four rune knights from the court climbed the hill, and the arrows did not pierce their protective clothing. For the first time, Kadan combined the movements learned from his six teachers and Malfuon's breathing on the battlefield. Rather than receiving the enemy's sword head-on, he slightly tilted his snow crystal shield and let it go through its orbit.

Kadan was embarrassed by the fact that he was much slower on the battlefield than on the practice field. There was a person lying on the floor and children crying behind them. Every time I swung my sword, I had to think about who would get hurt next. The perfect posture I had learned in training collapsed after just two attempts, and all that was left was breathing and choice.

He captured Ursoc, the son of enemy general Barghest, and instead of using him as a shield, he treated the wounded and sent him back. Because of that choice, the young soldiers in the enemy camp were shaken. This is because the mercy he saw before his eyes was more persuasive than his father's orders.

Gilgamesh and Titania gathered the young warriors and tied dry bushes to the tails of their horses. As hundreds of aircraft ran through the wilderness, dust pillars rose like thousands of armies. The besieging army changed its formation, thinking that reinforcements were coming, and Fenrir took advantage of that moment and escaped.

Three days later, Fenrir made a night raid on Barghest's headquarters again. After capturing his sworn brother, he punished the traitorous guard and allowed Barghest to die without shedding blood. Even amid the shouts of victory, Fenrir's face was not happy. What was buried that day was not just a necklace, but my entire childhood.

Several tribes in the Wildlands elected Fenrir as the conquering king. He showed the gold and dragon bone weapons from the treasure trove to Kadan, who had contributed, and told him to choose whichever he wanted.

Kadan chose to organize the list of fallen soldiers rather than celebrate. The names of young people who fought on the Barghest side were also written on the same board. When one of Fenrir's generals asked why he was honoring a traitor, Kadan replied that there was no need to kill someone who died due to a wrong order.

Give me the most precious thing.

Fenrir handed Titania's hand to Kadan. It was a declaration that the two would get married when they became adults. The crowd cheered, but Kadan and Titania couldn't see each other's faces. A childhood promise suddenly became tribal politics.

Elwin first revealed that her husband had promised to marry Balian and their children. Since Balian's child was a son, the marriage disappeared, but the promise that the descendants of the two families should meet remained. Kadan said he would return after finding Ignis and confirming the truth about his fathers.

Titania hid his disappointment and tightened the knot of the red string. I am not a treasure, Kadan. When you come back, ask me again if I will choose you then.

Kadan replied that that was correct. He left south with his six teachers, and Fenrir gave him a map in exchange for an order to bring Lucian's head. The map showed a secret supply route prepared by the Shadow Realm to invade the southern kingdom.

Rider of the Crimson Mane



Upon entering the southern plains, Kadan encountered a wild horse with a dark red mane. Instead of carrying a man on its back, the horse kicked and dented the armor of a soldier who came close. The auctioneers prepared tranquilizing arrows, but Kadan entered the fence empty-handed.

He didn't try to take the reins. He ran the same distance until the horse got tired, and when he stopped, he stopped too. As the sun was setting, the wild horse first touched the tip of its nose to his shoulder. Kadan called the horse Pegasus. This is because red frost crystals were scattered through its mane as it ran.

The auctioneer presented a contract and asked for the price of the horse. Kadan asked why the person who locked up the wild horse was the owner. Pegasus, who was watching the scuffle, broke down the fence and stood next to Kadan. The merchant retreated amid jeers from the crowd, who said even the choice of horse was priceless.

At the Janggagu Market on the outskirts of the capital, he saw a small beggar wearing a shabby cloak. The beggar was falsely accused of stealing bread and was surrounded by merchants, but instead of being frightened, he pointed out the flour stains on the soles of the thieves' shoes. As the real thief ran away, she kicked a rock with her toe, hitting the wheel axle exactly.

Kadan bought bread and warm soup from the beggar. Although his six teachers told him to use his old money sparingly, he even took off his fur coat to someone he met for the first time.

The beggar did not eat the soup in a hurry. First, I smelled the scent and stirred the floor once with a spoon. This is because I found out that there was a store that stole customers' money by putting sleeping vinegar in cheap soup. Kadan ate from his bowl first, and only then did he put a spoonful in his mouth.

Aren t you trusting strangers too much?

You don t seem to trust anyone.

The two looked at each other for a moment and then laughed at the same time. It was the first greeting from people facing the same problem in opposite directions.

Are all southerners so easily fooled? the beggar asked.

Anyone who pretends to be hungry to get soup must be really hungry.

The beggar laughed as if he were dumbfounded. She introduced herself as Celia and asked where Kadan was going and who she was looking for. Kadan didn't know how to hide it, and Celia changed its expression three times while listening. When the name Ignis came up, the laughter completely disappeared.

As the two people left the market, hunters who were trying to steal Pegasus blocked their path. Before Kadan drew his sword, Celia snapped his fingers. The wind spread the alley's awnings at once, blocking the hunters' view, and fruit crates rolled like wheels and hit their ankles.

You are not an ordinary beggar.

You re not an ordinary idiot either.

They headed to the capital together. A large duel stand was erected in the square in front of the castle gate. Wandering knight Balbo was holding a public sparring to find a spouse for his adopted daughter Eliana. There was only one condition: the person who pushed Eliana out of the duel without a weapon would be eligible to marry.

Eliana was not a weak product. Using the crystal bow and vine runes alternately, he quickly kicked out the challengers. However, when the young man in golden armor came up, the air in the square became hot. White flames bloomed from his hands and reduced the vines to ash.

Ignis checked the crowd's cheers before entering the duel. Each time a hand was raised, a flag with the royal emblem on it was unfurled. He did not come because he wanted to get married, but to test whether he was seen as a future king in the people's eyes.

Eliana avoided the flames and shot his bow three times. Ignis burned the first arrow and captured the second, but the third arrow pierced the crown decoration. The audience's brief laughter touched his pride. It was from that moment that Ignis became more cruel than necessary.

I am Ignis, the prince of the Red Glass Court.

Celia's voice lowered. Ignis did not raise his hand even after defeating Eliana. She threw her shoe into the audience, saying that marriage was just a game for low-class people. When Balbo protested, the flame whip burned the back of the old man's hand.

Kadan entered the duel. Although his teachers told him not to interfere in other people's business, he picked up the shoes that fell in front of Ignis and returned them to Eliana.

If you won, you have nothing more to prove. Why insult me?

Ignis saw the red string and old runes attached to Kadan's dagger. An unexplainable feeling of discomfort welled up in my chest. The children, connected by the promise of their two fathers, created snow and fire without even knowing each other's names.

Wind in Beggars Clothes



When Kadan's snow crystal shield and Ignis's white flame collided, the duel's rune stone split in half. Ignis's technique was fast and flashy, but the bigger the attack, the more gaps appeared in the next move. Kadan survived the gap by connecting different beats learned from six teachers.

As the game dragged on, Ignis raised his fingers like hooks. It was a life force extraction rune passed down by Medusa Gorgo. Kadan remembered the sign of the silver whip he had seen in the cave and turned his body, but his shoulder was deeply torn.

As Kadan's blood fell on the floor of the duel table, the hidden tracking symbol glowed red. It was a device that recorded the participants' mana so that the royal army could later find it. Celia sent wind down the stands, breaking the lines of the pattern one by one. While Kadan was fighting, she first noticed that the purpose of the duel was not winning or losing.

It was the paladin Walker who stopped the duel. He set up a blue barrier between the two and grabbed Ignis's wrist. Walker, a member of the same Star Sanctuary as Hercul, was astonished to see Ignis using both the Light Sword and Forbidden Arts that he had learned from his disciple.

Who taught you to do that?

Ignis did not reply. As the palace guards approached, he left the duel, saying only that he would not forget the insult. Kadan supported Balbo and Eliana, who had fallen. At that time, he heard six teachers calling out to him from among the crowd, but the moment he turned around, the people had already dispersed.

Walker was poisoned by Ignis's attack. The moon leaves needed for treatment were only found in the palace apothecary. When Kadan said he was going to enter the front door, Celia sighed.

Why is the only part of your plan that involves breaking down the door?

That night, Celia took off his old beggar clothes. Long, pointed elf ears were revealed from beneath her matted hair, and as she dusted off the lining of her cloak, her silver-blue dress unfolded like the wind. What she hid was not her name but her identity. Celia was the daughter of Aeolus, who ruled Whisper of the Wind Island.

Celia has prepared many situations in which Kadan will get angry. He first revealed how he hid his identity, tested his words, and even joked about asking for Pegasus. Kadan tilted his head when he heard the horse's name.

Pegasus is not something I give you. If you want to ride, ask Pegasus.

Celia didn't get any of the apples he expected. The simplicity of Kadan has sometimes most easily broken down a clever person's defenses.

Kadan forgot what to say for a while. Celia raised his eyebrows and barely opened his mouth.

You must have been cold in those clothes.

Celia laughed and wiped the corners of his eyes. That answer was more like Kadan than saying I was beautiful or deceived. From a young age, she received the vigilance and admiration of everyone on her father's island. He had just run away because he wanted to see how someone treated him when his identity was unknown.

The two sneaked into the pharmacy. Celia sent wind into the vent to eavesdrop on the guard's conversation, and Kadan stopped the vibration of the alarm rune with a thin film of ice. As I was about to turn around to look for the moon leaves, a fragrant bag slipped down the shelf.

In the pharmacy, confiscated herbs were piled up like a mountain and rotting. City doctors send patients away because they cannot find even a single antipyretic herb, but the palace keeps them in a warehouse to raise the price. Celia changed his plan to take only the moonlight leaves. I unsealed all the boxes and threw a note with the location written on it out the window.

When the citizens gathered in front of the warehouse at dawn the next day, the court could not hide the herbs. Kadan was amazed at how Celia could move through the city without breaking down the door.

The letter was sent from Lucian to Ignis. Instructions were written to poison Walker, capture Kadan, and eliminate Balbo before his identity is revealed. At the end of the letter, there was also an order to keep a woman named Ysela confined in the villa.

Kadan didn't know the name, but had a hunch that it could be Ignis's mother. Celia took the letter and set off a false fire alarm in the pharmacy. While the guards ran with buckets of water, the two escaped across the roof.

Walker survived with the moonleaf, but the poison was not completely removed. He said that he briefly learned runes from Hercul when Ignis was a baby, and that one day the court cut off visits between the child and his mother. The guilt of not being able to protect the child he taught silenced him for a long time.

The wind outside the window flipped the letter. Inside the envelope was a short sentence secretly written by Ignis.

If my mother is alive, why has she never looked for me?

Celia showed the sentence to Kadan. For the first time, the two saw that behind Ignis's arrogance was the face of an abandoned child.

Prisoner of the Flame Court



The red glass palace was as bright at night as during the day. A lava channel flowed inside the ceiling, and flame spirits floated in every hallway instead of lanterns. Kadan and Celia hung under the medicine cart and entered the villa.

Ysela lived alone in the old house at the end of the garden. Thatched roofs, old spinning wheels, and dirt-covered farm tools that did not match the splendid palace were laid out like a piece of home. Lucian placed a memory seal on her to make her forget the past, and tricked her into thinking that she was her dead husband's benefactor.

Ysela turned the potter's wheel at the same time every day and placed two teacups in the same place. I couldn't remember who I was waiting for. When Kadan said Balian's name, his hand first went to the empty teacup. Even though the head was forgotten, the body could not erase the person's place.

When Celia lifted the seal, Ysela saw the snowstorm from eighteen years ago again. Balian falling from a cliff, the black soldiers dragging him, the crying of a newborn baby. She sat down when she heard that Ignis was alive.

You think I abandoned that child.

At the same time, Ignis was heading to the villa after receiving orders from Lucian. It was an order to personally capture the intruders of the pharmacy and prove their loyalty. He heard Kadan's voice and Ysela's crying at the door.

When Ignis opened the door, white flames filled the room. Kadan spread his shield but did not fight back. Celia also took the blow and let Ysela step forward.

Ysela did not retreat even in the flames. The feeling of carrying Ignis out of a tent on fire as a newborn made me move my feet. When she stretched out her hand, Ignis's flames only circled around her finger.

Please don't come closer. Ignis's voice cracked.

Don't stop if you don't want to. This time, I don't want to listen to your wishes and get taken away.

Ysela stopped on the spot. Instead of running to hug him, I left the option for my son to choose.

You have a crescent-shaped scar on your right shoulder. Ysela said. The fire was so hot when it was born that I put an ice towel on it and the marks were made.

Ignis's fire wavered. It was a scar that I had never shown to anyone. He took a step forward and then took a step back. The life he had built up at the court, hating his mother as a traitor his entire life, could not be destroyed with a single sentence.

Lucian was already watching everything from the roof. He activated the destruction rune hidden in Ysela's memory seal. As the black flame penetrated her heart, Ignis instinctively hugged her mother. The cold of Kadan and the flame of Ignis enveloped the rune at the same time, and the opposing forces were balanced for a moment.

Kadan felt that if the ice was even a little strong, Ysela's heart would stop. Ignis was also able to burn the memories along with the seal by turning up the heat. The two, unaware of each other's breathing, increased their strength as much as the other person backed away, and immediately lowered it when the other person faltered. The first cooperation was born not of trust but of a common fear of saving one person.

Now you have become a useful brother.

Lucian came down with the palace guards. After hearing that he had plotted his father's death, Kadan drew his dagger. However, Lucian took Ysela hostage and said that Balian was still alive. He was a nameless prisoner in a labor prison beneath the palace.

Ignis failed to aim his sword at Lucian. The man raised him as a prince, gave him power and technology, and at the same time took away his biological parents. Neither memory was a lie. While he was hesitating, security guards poured into the room.

Celia gathered the wind from the garden and burst the glass wall. Kadan carried Ysela and ran outside, and the carriage prepared by Walker and Eliana waited under the fence. Ignis received orders to chase, but deliberately set fire to the opposite corridor to block the guard's path.

Lucian did not miss the action. How does it feel to meet your mother?

I haven't yet confirmed if that woman is my mother.

Ignis's voice was cold, but the flames inside his fist were burning the blood.

Ysela, who left the palace, saw Kadan's dagger and recognized Aleksandar. She described the last moment when Balian pushed her away to avoid Lucian's pursuit. For the first time, the tragedies of two families were connected in one memory.

Inside the carriage, Ysela looked at Kadan's face several times. His eyebrows resembled his father's, and his habit of slightly tilting his head when listening to people was similar to Elwin. Kadan pieced together the memories of his father, whom he had never met, from other people's memories.

Kadan said he would go back to the dungeon and rescue Balian. Celia did not stop him and unfolded the palace drainage map. Ignis was looking at them from the top of the red glass tower in the distance. Between the flame and the snow now lay a path not only toward hatred but toward the same truth.

PART II



The Courts of Wind and Flame

The Dagger That Wakes Memory



The labor prison where Balian was imprisoned was connected to an abandoned mine below the palace. The prisoners were called by the numbers on their iron necklaces instead of their names, and they lost their memories as they dug for firestones all day. Celia calculated patrol intervals by reading the wind in the drainage channel, and Kadan created a temporary bridge over the lava channel with an ice film.

In the deepest pit, they found an old man lame on one leg. His face was covered in scars, but his hand holding the broken spear was still strong. The moment the old man saw Kadan's silver dagger, he dropped his pickaxe.

Balian was teaching prisoners to read. The date of the day and the name of the dead person were carved into the flamestone wall with a pickaxe. Not losing my memory was the only resistance I could do in prison. Kadan found his father Aleksandar's name on one side of the wall. It was a name that Balian re-engraved every day for eighteen years.

Kadan Brother's sword.

Balian didn't die on the cliff eighteen years ago. After being captured by palace soldiers downriver, he survived by hiding his identity to find out Ysela's whereabouts. Lucian recognized him but did not kill him. Because he was waiting for the day when he would make Ignis execute his biological father.

During the escape, Ignis blocked the way. Kadan threw him a letter, and Balian showed his son the family window. The movement of seeming to retreat and then turning the tip of the spear upside down was a family protection ritual that was not passed down to anyone.

The color disappeared from Ignis's face. It was a movement he had repeated in his dreams when he was young. He believed that the traces of his father that his body remembered were the teachings of his royal instructor.

Balian hit Ignis's window once and straightened the handle. If you raise your thumb like that, flames will burn your wrist. The scolding tone was so natural that Ignis corrected his hands as if he had become a child for a moment. He soon realized what he had done and roughly shook the spear away.

That man is a prisoner. Ignis said. The prisoner's words and descriptions cannot serve as evidence.

Then check it yourself. Kadan answered. Instead of wielding fire, ask questions.

When the alarm sounded, Balian pushed Ignis away and opened the escape hatch. Unable to harm his son, he turned the tip of his spear over to its end. Ignis did not chase, but did not go together either. I remained between the iron bars and looked for a long time in the direction where my father had disappeared.

Six teachers were waiting on earth. They were angry that Kadan had infiltrated the palace without telling them, and were even more surprised to learn that Celia was Aeolus's daughter. In particular, Grimli did not trust people from Wind Island. This is because Medusa Gorgo, who killed Robinyard a long time ago, was also a disciple of that island.

The argument ended with a surprise attack by Medusa Gorgo. She made a deal with the court to get the other half of the codex in exchange for Balian. As the silver whip aimed at Celia, Kadan threw his body to block it, and Medusa Gorgo grabbed his neck.

You are the ones who killed Belphegor.

Kadan said that Belphegor saved him in the rapids. Medusa Gorgo's hands relaxed for a moment. In the meantime, Gawain's staff wrapped around the

whip, and the remaining teachers pulled Kadan out.

During the battle, Medusa Gorgo heard the sound of six people's silver bells. It was the drop of Robinyard, who died on the Mistfall cliff. Her revenge for losing her husband and their revenge for losing their colleague collided on the same night. No one acknowledged the other's sadness, and the fight became more brutal.

Balian destroyed the floor with his spear, separating the two sides. Today is not the day for children to inherit their parents' resentment.

Underneath the collapsed floor, there was a small escape passage dug by the prisoners. Balian did not use the opportunity to go out on his own for several years, and widened the gap to pass until the last prisoner. Kadan group stopped fighting and led the mine people to the ground first.

Medusa Gorgo retreated into the darkness, but left a warning to Celia. Do you know how many disciples Aeolus abandoned to protect the secrets of the codex? Celia could not answer. One of the reasons I ran away from my father was because of that silence.

Kadan The group hid in an abandoned sanctuary outside the city. When Balian and Ysela stood face to face, the two could not immediately hug. The eighteen lost years were so long that I didn't even know where to put my hands. Kadan quietly closed the door.

Spring Between Two Graves



The location of the abandoned sanctuary was discovered within a day. Lucian lost its justification to control Ignis when it was revealed that Balian was alive. He surrounded the sanctuary not only with the palace guards but also with Magitech Golem, which had been modified with forbidden arts.

Balian tried to go out the back door with Ysela, but the wound from Medusa Gorgo's fingernails was spreading black. He realized with his body that Ignis's life force extraction rune came from the same poison. The more I ran, the stiffer my limbs became.

Hercul and Walker opened the way. The six masters guarded the sanctuary steps, and Celia pulled the wounded out into the wind tunnel. Kadan found it difficult to bear the fact that even though people from his parents' generation were gathered together again, no one had time to rejoice.

Lucian appeared in person and extended his hand to Ysela. When you return to the palace, I will spare Balian's life.

Ysela couldn't forgive himself for once wanting to believe those words. She turned her back on Lucian, holding Balian's hand. Balian used his remaining strength to raise a spear to block his wife and Kadan.

At that time, Ignis landed in front of the royal army. Everyone waited for his choice. He approached Balian and instead of kneeling, he aimed the tip of his spear. Lucian smiled with satisfaction.

However, Ignis's flame did not burn Balian's body, but the destruction rune in the ground. The device that was supposed to bury the entire sanctuary lost its

light. I will not call you father yet, nor will I kill you by order of you.

Balian saw his son's face up close for the first time. A poison touched my heart as I searched for what to say. He leaned on Ysela's shoulder and asked Kadan to show him the truth before hating Ignis.

Ysela held out a small wooden horse to Ignis. It was a toy that was kept in the baby's crib until the day of the kidnapping. The court tried to get rid of all her past, but she hid it by sewing it into the lining of her skirt. Ignis did not accept it, and the wooden piece was placed on the floor between the two.

Lucian's arrow flew. Balian wrapped his wife with his last strength, and Ysela held on to the arrow lodged in his chest and did not let go. The two people called each other's names once and then died in the same place.

Ignis's fireworks ran wild. The stone pillars of the sanctuary melted and the armor of the palace soldiers turned red. Kadan spread a snow crystal shield to protect the people. He walked into the middle of the fire without attacking Ignis.

What you are burning now is not Lucian, but those are the last words you could hear.

Ignis grabbed Kadan by the collar, but could not lower his fist. Lucian took advantage of the confusion and fled. The remaining royal forces followed their master and retreated.

Balian and Ysela were buried together on a hill overlooking the village of Elwin. Hercul knelt down, saying that if he had been a little less impatient 18 years ago, he might have prevented the tragedy. Grimli raised him up, saying that it was the vanity of the living to only express regrets in front of the dead.

Kadan did not write down the numbers of the two palace prisoners on the tombstone. Balian's name was engraved on the prison wall, and the two empty teacups that Ysela had left next to the potter's wheel were placed in front of the grave. Celia hung a small wind chime with the wind and made a sound when

someone came by.

After the funeral, Ignis disappeared. In front of the tomb, only a single flame solidified in white glass remained. Kadan did not clean it up.

When no one was looking, Ignis returned and buried the wooden horse among the graves. He felt that if he kept the evidence that his mother had found him, he would not be able to return to the palace. However, I couldn't throw it away. For the first time, no white flames bloomed from his hands covering the dirt.

Celia took Kadan far away to the riverside. She didn't choose words of comfort. Instead, he divided the warm bread in half and handed it to me. Just like Kadan did to himself in the first market. Kadan waited a while before accepting the bread.

Young grass was coming up between the two graves. It was too little green to say that winter was over, but that day Kadan learned for the first time that sadness and life could grow on the same land.

Master of the Jade Staff



Heading south, Kadan and Celia smelled grilling meat on the forest road. The owner of the scent was Leonar, an old warrior with a huge lion's mane. He lay down with his green jade staff as a pillow and freely evaluated the meal the two had prepared.

Instead of getting angry, Celia looked at the remaining ingredients. There were only dried mushrooms, tough boar meat, and sour berries, but the wind divided the temperature of the fire and let the herbal scent seep into the meat. Leonar took his first bite and opened his eyes wide.

Leonar did not say that it was delicious, but criticized the cooking of the meat and the amount of salt. When Celia tried to snatch the plate away, he swallowed the last piece whole. Kadan laughed when he saw that, but even his share was taken away by Leonar. The teacher-disciple relationship between the three began across the dining table.

What is the price?

Teach my friend an attack technique other than a shield.

Kadan was surprised that Celia asked for something before him. Leonar looked at Kadan's shoulders and feet and commented that he had enough strength but did not know where to stop his strength.

What he taught was the first of the eighteen Dragon Breaker seals. It was not a technique that caused a large explosion of mana. It was a method of accurately delivering a single impact while leaving the force to move back.

Kadan couldn't shake a single tree for three days. The leaves fell off on the 10th day, and after a month, only the rotted parts inside the trunk were pushed out without breaking the tree. Leonar admitted that he had finally learned his first seal.

Celia did not just watch the water lilies. The point at which Kadan's mana leaks is indicated by the temperature of the wind. At first, there were too many instructions, which made Kadan's movements more complicated, but the two reduced the signals to three. Left, pause, breath. It was a language that would later be used faster than hundreds of words on the battlefield.

A swarm of Medusa Gorgo snake spirits flocked to that forest. The spirits swelled by sucking the mana of living beasts, and the white-cloaked trainers used flutes to change direction. Leonar drew a line on the ground with a green jade staff, creating a barrier that snakes could not cross.

Celia was bitten by two small snakes, but the windscale armor he wore under his clothes repelled his teeth. Kadan tried to freeze the snake swarm with his frost mana, which was immune to poison. Leonar stopped him.

If you kill everyone because they are easy to kill, you will fight in a way determined by the enemy.

The three found the frequency of the training flute and turned it over with the wind. The snake spirits turned towards their owners and the trainers ran away. Although Medusa Gorgo did not appear, a revenge emblem directed at Aeolus was scratched on the tree bark.

Leonar was a wandering leader of the Freeman's League. An organization where wanderers and refugees, not kings or nobles, feed each other. The green jade staff was the key to proving the leader. He looked at Celia's judgment and Kadan's restraint.

On the day of leaving, Leonar promised to teach Kadan the remaining seventeen seals in the future. The conditions were not grand. Even after

gaining strength, sit at the same table as hungry people.

Leonar never revealed the name of the first seal. The reason was that if you learn the name first, people will imitate the legend rather than the movement. Kadan called it the hand that leaves behind the strength to return the way it was created. Leonar laughed and said it was tacky, but did not change it.

He left heavier words for Celia. Daughter of the Wind Island, the day will never come when you become a leader because of your bloodline. But if people trust your judgment and hand you a staff, do not run away.

Kadan did not ask why Celia suddenly became silent. Instead, Pegasus slowed down and walked side by side with her. At the end of the forest, a huge lake of fog spread out in silver light under the sunlight.

Guests of the Mist Lake



The fog lake was as wide as the sea. Instead of the horizon, seventy-two stone island islands supported the clouds, and the towers of an old underwater city were submerged beneath the water. Kadan and Celia rented a small boat and entered the center of the lake.

A singing voice was heard in the fog. It was a wind lullaby that Celia learned from Aeolus when he was young. As she sang the next verse, the one-legged ship owner Rondol appeared. He was once a disciple of Aeolus, but after losing his leg and being driven off the island, he was guarding a refuge for refugees here.

Rondol did not bow even after recognizing who Celia was. The child who ran away is back on his feet. Celia also did not call him teacher. The two took the oars one by one without telling each other why they were angry. Kadan just looked at the waves in the meantime.

Rondol took the two people to the Cloud Return Mansion. On the wall were hanging mana circuits and ancient maps that looked like paintings. Kadan didn't read much, but he noticed that the strokes of the circuit resembled the movement of a sword. Celia laughed as he saw him slashing the air with his fingers in front of the painting.

The peace on the lake did not last long. The Red Glass Court's warship plundered the fishing village under the pretext of paying taxes, and at the head of it was Ignis, who was chained up. After leaving the palace after the death of his parents, he was captured and was forced to wear a control device that tightened the flame core whenever he refused orders from Lucian.

Rondol's son, Kaze, attacked the military ship and took Ignis prisoner. The people in the mansion wanted to execute him immediately, but Kadan stopped them. Ignis refused help and attempted to melt the chains himself. As the control sphere burned the heart, Celia only cut the rune line with the wind knife.

In the prisoner's room, Ignis asked Kadan about his parents' last appearance. When Kadan tried to tell the truth, he was immediately stopped. I asked because I wanted to hear it, but I couldn't bear to hear Kadan's story about a time when I wasn't there.

Kadan only provided the location of the grave. You can go later when you're ready. There are things there that I don't need to explain.

Don't pity me. Ignis said.

Don't get me wrong. I saved you because Lucian would be happy if you died.

At Celia's answer, Ignis couldn't find anything to say to be more angry.

That night, Belphegor, a nobleman holding a metal fan, appeared at the mansion. After surviving the rapids, he separated from Medusa Gorgo and led the Western Poison Dragon. Every time the fan was opened, poisonous needles and small snake spirits poured out. He took Ignis and tried to use it to decipher Medusa Gorgo's codex.

While Kadan and Belphegor were fighting, Celia activated the mansion's picture circuit. The fog created a different exit for each room, and the Gunseon and Poison Dragons fought each other, mistaking each other for enemies. Rondol turned the water wheel on his wheelchair and turned the lake water into a wall.

Ignis had a chance to escape. However, when Belphegor's fan aimed at Kadan's back, the stinger burned with white flames. Your life is a debt I must repay. I will not hand it over to anyone else.

A poisonous needle stuck in Ignis's shoulder. When Celia tried to pull it out, he slapped his hand away, but his knees soon buckled. While Kadan held him, Celia slowed the flow of poison into the wind. It was the first moment when the three acted as one body without trusting each other.

Belphegor retreated and informed Celia that Medusa Gorgo was heading to Wind Island. Aeolus was trying to retrieve the hidden original codex and his own past.

The people in the mansion tried to lock up Ignis, but Rondol released the chains. Master kicked me off the island, but he couldn't take away my right to choose. You don't have to be the person the court decides.

Ignis left for the other side of the lake. Kadan and Celia didn't know which side he would be on. In the early morning fog, the three boats headed in different directions, but their destination was Whisper of the Wind Island.

Night of Serpent and Lion



A skull-shaped crystal box was delivered to the Cloud Return Mansion. Five finger prints were deeply engraved on the lid, and on the inside, the emblem of Medusa Gorgo, which said to come back in three days, glowed. Rondol's face turned pale. In the past, he was the one who chased down Medusa Gorgo and Belphegor under the orders of Aeolus.

Rondol attempted to send his family and refugees off the island. Since it was a grudge he had created, he thought he would handle it alone. Celia opposed the decision. He shot back that his attitude of keeping secrets to himself was the same as Aeolus.

The residents of the mansion also did not leave. Rondol thought he was protecting them, but the fishermen, potters, and children already considered this place their home. After hearing that no one had asked him to die on his behalf, Rondol was the first to withdraw his order.

On the third night, a strange old man, Orihalcon, came instead of Medusa Gorgo. He claimed to be the Grand Elder of the Iron Palm Mountains and demanded a large sum of money, saying he could break steel with his bare hands and revive a dead person's runes. Even after being hit by Kadan's Dragon Breaker once, he smiled normally.

Celia saw a magnetic device tremble beneath his boots. Rather than breaking the steel, it was a trick of cracking it in advance and pulling the pieces with a magnet at the moment of impact. The assistant behind the scenes was also manipulating the crystal that revived dead runes.

Orihalcon, whose identity was revealed, did not run away. Rather, he unleashed his true hidden power. Iron Palm's compressed mana exploded continuously through both arms. Kadan blocked the first attack, but the second and third impacts exploded inside the shield.

Orihalcon claimed that he distributed the money he earned through fraud to poor miners. Celia said that whether what he said was true and whether it was right to deceive people are two different things. His habit of putting evil and good deeds on both sides of the scale and erasing each other was stripped away in one sentence.

Just because you fool people with fake miracles doesn't mean your power is fake. Celia shouted to Kadan. The impact moves to the other arm. Don't hit first, wait for the moment it comes back!

Kadan folded his shield and took a step inside. In the short space where Orihalcon's power passed from his left arm to his right arm, he pushed the Dragon Breaker. The old man's armor cracked, but Kadan only broke his shoulder, avoiding his heart.

At that moment, all the lights in the mansion went out. A real visitor, Medusa Gorgo, came in through the fog. Using Orihalcon as bait, she arrived at Rondol's room and snatched the deportation order from Aeolus.

In the order, under the sentence to capture Medusa Gorgo and Belphegor alive, there was a secret instruction to bury them with their disciples if it was impossible to retrieve the codex. Rondol did not follow the command and lost his leg. For the first time, Medusa Gorgo realized that the person who did not try to kill him was Rondol.

Medusa Gorgo's whip shook as he lost his direction for revenge. At that time, Belphegor led the Poison Dragons and surrounded the mansion. He believed that Medusa Gorgo had abandoned him, and he sought revenge on everyone by obtaining the codex.

Medusa Gorgo returned the welcome stone to Belphegor. A scene of two young people and young Celia laughing appeared above the fog. Belphegor stretched out his hand for a moment, but seeing his past self seemed to forgive his present self, so he broke the illusion stone.

Kadan, Celia, Rondol, and Medusa Gorgo briefly became on the same side and fought against the Poison Dragons. The fog circuit bound the enemy's feet, and Medusa Gorgo's chain whip snatched the fan. Kadan kept Belphegor alive again, but this time he clearly stated the reason.

It s not just because you saved my life once. It means that you live to see the end of your choice.

Belphegor laughed and threw himself into the lake. Medusa Gorgo did not follow him. She left, saying she would hear the answer directly from Aeolus on Wind Island.

After the battle, only broken paintings and water-soaked ledgers remained in the mansion. Celia was afraid to meet his father. Instead of just saying that it would be okay, Kadan said that he would be by my side no matter what answer I got. The tide toward Wind Island on the other side of the lake began to change.

Brothers Before the Ruins



The day before leaving for Whisper of the Wind Island, the fog at Cloud Return Mansion parted for a moment. Aeolus holding a black flute walked in on the water. The wind supported his feet but made no sound.

When Celia saw his father, he felt more angry than happy. He asked all at once the order to kill Medusa Gorgo, the banishment of Rondol, and the silence that had closed all doors after his mother's death. Instead of explaining, Aeolus looked at his daughter's face and wounds.

He raised his hand and lowered it when he saw that the way Celia had tied his hair when he was young had changed. He didn't know if he still had the right to tidy up his tangled hair like before. Celia became angrier when he saw that small hesitation, and at the same time, he could not pour out any more words.

You re alive.

That one word made Celia more angry. Did you think all you had to do was stay alive? Did the people your father abandoned think the same way?

Medusa Gorgo came down from the roof. She aimed the chain whip at Aeolus's back, but Aeolus didn't even turn around. The past orders were not forged. He believed that tens of thousands of people would be sacrificed if the Codex fell to the Shadow Realm, and he chose to abandon several of his disciples.

Rondol showed the leg he lost because of that choice. Medusa Gorgo called the name of the dead Belphegor. This was the first time Celia heard that his mother, Sylphid, lost her life while deciphering the codex. The world that Aeolus tried to protect was always bigger than specific people.

Kadan did not intend to be a judge. However, I asked Aeolus. Would you do that again if the same situation came up?

There was no answer for a long time. Finally, Aeolus put down the flute. If it were me in the past, I would have done that. I don't know now. I lost too many people to admit that I don't know.

Rondol lifted the blanket on his knees to reveal his missing leg. If I had heard the answer back then that I didn't know, I might have stayed. Aeolus did not see the wound and lowered his head. Realizing that being silent because of the late apology was another escape, he eventually called out his student's name and said that he had made a mistake.

Medusa Gorgo didn't kill him. Not because I forgave him, but because I didn't want to end the answer with death. She headed to Wind Island, saying she would first find the original codex.

Aeolus did not order Celia to return. Instead, it was announced that the island's barrier was collapsing, and that the Western Poisonous Dragons and the Red Glass Court were approaching at the same time. Celia said he would go back not for the island, but for the people living on it.

The moment I was about to leave the mansion, Ignis appeared. He was putting a handful of dirt from the graves of Balian and Ysela into a small glass jar. While chasing Lucian, I had just discovered that the palace fleet was heading to Wind Island.

Kadan took Ignis to the grave. In front of the tombstone, the two people placed the silver daggers left behind by their fathers side by side. Ignis said that he did not deserve to be a brother because he ignored his biological father.

Ignis took the wooden horse out of the dirt again. It was wet from the rain and the colors were smudged, but one wheel still turned. Kadan did not offer to fix it. Ignis was next to hand over a small knife and a dry cloth until he cleaned it himself.

It s not a promise you make because you re qualified. Kadan held out his hand. We make a deal to pull each other out the next time we go down the wrong path.

Ignis held hands after a while. The two were not brothers with the same parents, nor were they colleagues who covered each other's sins. They ended up promising to tell the truth that the other person didn't want to hear.

Celia became anxious as he watched the two people make their vows. Kadan's good intentions could have saved Ignis, and could have been used for his own ambitions. Ignis also read Celia's eyes.

You don t have to trust me.

That is not permitted. Celia answered.

The three people boarded the same boat, but headed to Wind Island for different reasons. Kadan to keep his father's promise, Celia to confront his father's choices, and Ignis to prove that his spark is no one's command.

Invitation to the Wind Isle



On the second day of sailing, a Griffon followed the ship from the north. A red letter of Titania was tied to her ankle. Fenrir officially announced her marriage to Kadan, and Wildland warriors were preparing to come down to the south.

Kadan read the letter several times. I never forgot my promise to Titania. However, the words they said to return to each other when they were young and the marriage announced by the Conqueror were not the same thing. Celia pretended to be okay and just looked at the route.

Celia marked and erased the same constellation on the map three times. Ignis silently marked a dot on the correct route. Although the two did not like each other, they both agreed on the fact that Celia was hurting alone while Kadan was delaying the answer.

Ignis broke the silence first. If you postpone a decision because you don't want to lose both of them, you end up passing the cost of the decision on to both of them.

Kadan knew that those words were also Ignis's own story. He delayed too long choosing between the court and his parents.

Whisper of the Wind Island was not where it was marked on the map. As the sun set, the sound of Aeolus's flute spread over the sea, and the fog parted like stairs. The forest surrounding the island had leaves of different colors depending on the season, and the location of the road changed every time you looked back.

The three people dispersed at the entrance. Kadan fell into the forest that swallows up sound, Celia fell into the mansion of my childhood, and Ignis fell into the garden where flames do not burn. The barrier trapped the intruder's strongest regrets by turning them into a path.

Kadan saw himself returning to the north in a vision. It was a life of forming a peaceful family with Titania and serving Elwin. There was neither Celia nor Ignis on that road. It was a cruel welcome because he seemed happy.

Welcome Titania didn't ask any questions, and Elwin praised all of his son's choices. Only then did Kadan realize that what he was seeing was not love, but rest without resistance. He cut the bread in half on the table, but there was no smell or warmth inside.

In Celia's vision, his mother Sylphid was alive. Aeolus was friendly, and Medusa Gorgo and Rondol also did not leave the island. When the young Celia held out his hand, the current Celia wanted to hold it. But in perfect memory, no one ever said anything about their mistakes. She opened the window and let a welcome breeze flow outside.

Ignis was sitting on the throne. Lucian was on his knees and Kadan was chained, defeated. It had all the power and recognition he wanted, but the flame was cold and smellless. Ignis melted the crown to create a road.

As the crown melted, numerous names were revealed beneath the throne. These were the names of mine prisoners, war orphans, and people he had insulted in duels. When Ignis saw that he was sitting on the seat erected above them, he cut off Kadan's chains in the illusion.

The three met again in the sound garden in the center of the island. Aeolus's flute and Medusa Gorgo's whip were clashing together. The sound of the flute turned people's senses upside down, and Medusa Gorgo survived with the vibration of the ground instead of snow.

Celia stepped into the fight and separated the voices of the two with the wind.
Where is the codex?

Aeolus answered that it was sealed in the underground temple. But the temple door was already open from the inside. Someone had entered the island's barrier ahead of time.

White flame marks remained on the floor. Ignis declared that it was not his spark. It was an artificial flame created from the blood and runes that Lucian had collected to clone him.

Celia returned Titania's letter to Kadan. Write the answer before you leave the island. Don't leave hope as bait to anyone.

Kadan nodded. He tried to hold Celia's hand for the first time and stopped. Celia grabbed his finger first. It was a brief contact, but Ignis pretended not to see and walked ahead.

Secret of the Black Sanctum



There were no books in the basement of the temple. The entire black wall was a huge memory device, with thousands of sentences floating around with light and sound. The Nine Shadows Codex was not one person's secret book, but a record of life mana research left behind by a fallen civilization.

Aeolus explained that the codex can be used for healing and life extension, but if read in reverse order, it becomes a forbidden art that takes away the life force of others. Celia's mother, Sylphid, died when her memory and mind were connected while trying to correct a mistranslation.

Inside the temple, an old man named Gandar was trapped. He was a heroic priest who founded the Star Sanctuary and a long-time enemy of Aeolus. Aeolus said he locked him up because he knew the location of the codex, but Gandar claimed he stayed because it was fun.

Gandar's prison door was not locked. He said that he ate more regularly inside than outside and that it was easy to make fun of Aeolus, so he didn't go out. When Celia did not believe him, he showed him twelve escape hatches he had secretly dug over the past ten years. It was like everyone went out about halfway and then came back because they were bored.

When Gandar saw Kadan, he immediately asked him to become his younger brother. The more Kadan tried to be polite, the more he rolled on the floor and laughed.

Don't use adult language. The most dangerous runes in this temple can never be learned by someone with dignity.

What he showed was binary splitting. A technique to simultaneously defend and attack by sending different mana commands to the left and right hands. Kadan had a simple idea, so he learned it rather quickly. He raised a snow crystal shield with one hand and created the first seal of Dragon Breaker with the other hand.

From the first attempt, Celia created different winds with both hands, but the two flows were intertwined too intricately and he got himself caught in a knot. Ignis tried to use two attacks at the same time, but both flames collided. Gandar laughed, holding his stomach and saying that the two smartest people would take the longest.

Celia found the voice of Sylphid in the codex records. Instead of telling people not to blame Aeolus, the last study left a warning saying, Do not trust interpretations that make someone's sacrifice for granted. It was a sentence I wrote with the belief that my daughter would read it someday.

In his memory, after Sylphid finished talking about his research, he even left young Celia instructions on how to comb his hair and a recipe for his favorite soup. There was no difference between the knowledge to save the world and the knowledge to survive each day. It was only at that point that Celia cried quietly.

Ignis discovered a structure identical to his fingernail rune in the forbidden arts section. The technique taught by Medusa Gorgo was the reverse translation of the codex. Every time he attacked a person, some of the opponent's mana flowed into the flame core, and that power was slowly destroying the core.

How to get rid of it? Ignis asked.

Giving back what you have received. Gandar answered. It's not that you're losing strength, it's that you're letting go of strength that wasn't yours. It's going to hurt a lot.

A warning sound sounded. Artificial white flames were melting the outer walls of the temple. Magitech Golem sent by Lucian copied the island's defense system and opened the door from the inside. Someone had already transmitted part of the codex to the outside world.

Medusa Gorgo said he was not the criminal. What she wanted was the truth, not Lucian's victory. For the first time, Aeolus did not doubt his disciple's words. The four people separated the memory device and each took a different piece. This was to prevent one person from monopolizing the entire codex.

Gandar gave Kadan a final warning. Binary splitting is not a technique to create two minds, and it is a way for one person to take on different responsibilities at the same time. The problem will not be solved if you choose between love and duty. You have to look at both clearly and choose.

Kadan wrote a reply to Titania that night. Although he treasured the promise he made when he was young, he could not marry by the Conqueror's declaration, and he openly wrote that he had fallen in love with Celia. My writing hand trembled more than when I held the sword.

Celia did not read the letter. I just sat next to Kadan, who had finished sealing, and put our shoulders to each other. Above the temple, Magitech Golem's footsteps were getting closer and closer.

Three Trials



Aeolus said he would test Kadan before leaving the island. I had no intention of granting my daughter's heart like an object, but I had to check if she was someone who would become an enemy of the island while holding the codex piece. Celia objected, saying that his choice should not be tested.

It is not my marriage that is being tested, but my judgment. Kadan said. I already heard your choice.

The first test began in the acoustic garden. As Aeolus played the flute, resonant waves like invisible blades rushed in from all directions. Kadan did not stop his ears and listened to the tremors of the ground as he had learned from Gawain. Instead of spreading the shield wide, it split the waves by floating small snow crystals at each node of the sound.

Aeolus mixed the lullaby that Celia used to sing when he was young when he couldn't sleep between the attack sounds. The reason why Kadan's concentration was shaken was not because of the power of the sound, but because he heard Celia stop breathing next to him. Instead of continuing the test, he lowered his shield for a moment to check Celia. Aeolus did not count that choice as a failure.

The opponent for the second test was Ignis. Aeolus said that the person who protects the codex fragments needs the ability to stop the force. Kadan and Ignis faced each other in the temple ring.

Ignis used smaller flames than before. After starting to return the power of the forbidden technique, my body became weaker, but my control became more sophisticated. Kadan deployed both defense and attack simultaneously through

dual division. Even though snow and fire hit it dozens of times, not a single flower outside the circular platform was burned.

The two men did not shout out the names of the attacks and there were no spectators. Because of this, we were able to see each other's faces in more detail than at the first duel table. Ignis noticed that Kadan protected his left knee, and Kadan noticed that Ignis continued to reduce the spark near his heart.

The match ended with Kadan's fist stopping in front of Ignis's chest, and Ignis's flame stopping in front of Kadan's neck at the same time. Aeolus has not decided on a winner. The two people who stopped said they both passed the test.

The final test was to remember a thousand random sentences from the codex and restore them backwards. Kadan had a slow reading speed. Ignis rarely forgot a rune once he saw it, and even Celia thought that Kadan was at a disadvantage this time.

Gandar taught Kadan a shortcut. It was a method of physically remembering the movement of a sentence rather than memorizing its meaning. Kadan linked each rune to the movements of the six teachers, the northern constellations, and the wind path created by Celia. When giving the correct answer, he did not recite the sentence, but drew it on the temple floor with his sword and his steps.

When he couldn't remember the last sentence, Celia didn't give a hint. Instead, the bowl of soup that the two of them had initially shared at the market was placed on the floor. Kadan recalled the rotating rune missing from the edge of the round bowl. Aeolus confirmed the answer that knowledge does not exist separately from people.

After the three exams, Aeolus tried to call Kadan his son-in-law. Celia immediately cut him off.

It's not the name your father would give you. We still have work to do, and we'll decide on marriage later.

Kadan also nodded. Aeolus smiled bitterly and said that he would learn the difference between a command and a blessing only when he got older.

At that time, the sea-side barrier collapsed. Lucian's fleet and Belphegor's poisonous dragon ship entered the island at the same time. Magitech Golem was paving the way by replicating the sound of Aeolus's flute.

Ignis reached out to Kadan. The time has come to keep my oath. If I fight the court's way again, drag me out.

Celia connected all wind towers on the island. At her command, the forest path moved and the coastal cliffs folded into a huge maze. She was no longer a daughter who ran away from home, nor was she a successor following in her father's footsteps. The people of the island began to follow her voice.

The Wave That Swallowed the Flower Ship



There were no war ships in the port of Wind Island. Celia created an evacuation boat by connecting flower boats used during festivals. The children and the elderly were placed in the central cabin, and the fog passage was opened with Aeolus's flute. The colorful flower decorations were a target in the night sea, but there was no time to take them off.

Instead of tearing down the flower decorations, the islanders hung empty cloth bags under the flowers. It had a structure that caught the wind when an arrow flew, forming a small shield. The tailors preparing for the festival repaired the sails faster than the war engineers. Rather than giving orders, Celia connected each person's skills to where they were needed.

Lucian's fleet bombarded the island. The artificial white flame did not go out even on the water and followed the evacuation ship. Ignis stood on the bow and read the structure of the same flame. It was a replica made of his blood, but it was designed to react to fear and anger.

The more I shake, the stronger that fire becomes.

Kadan did not erect a shield in front of Ignis. Then shake it. Instead, don't hold on alone.

For the first time, Ignis did not hide his fear. The death of his parents, the voice of Lucian, and the fear of losing his throne were spoken one by one. Emotions expressed in words were no longer prey to fake flames. The moment the flames abated, Celia turned the wind and sent it back to the enemy fleet.

His confession wasn't cool. Sentences were often interrupted, he said the same thing twice, and when he admitted to being jealous of Kadan, the flames flew again. Kadan did not give advice and waited for the next words. When Ignis finally said, I still want to be king, the mock flame shook the most and then went out.

In Poison Dragon Ship, Belphegor called Medusa Gorgo. He said that if you turn over the codex piece, you can go back to the past. Medusa Gorgo cut his fan in two with a chain whip.

There is no past we can go back to. So make the right choice at least next time.

Belphegor was furious and caused the Poison Dragon Ship's heart path to explode. The crew members trapped inside the ship were in danger of dying together. Kadan crossed over to the enemy ship and freed the crew, while Ignis drew the heat from the heart into its core. The pain of returning the power that had been taken away through the forbidden liquor tore through my entire body.

Celia cut off all the sails on the flower boat and turned them into a huge wind net. I tried to push the poisonous dragon ship that was about to explode into the empty sea, but Belphegor held the rudder and did not let go. Medusa Gorgo held his hand for the last time.

Don't ask me to go with you. Belphegor said. At least one person has to make the next choice.

He pushed Medusa Gorgo into the sea. The poisonous dragon ship exploded and a pillar of black fire rose. The shock wave broke the connection of the flower boat and scattered the refuge ships in all directions.

Kadan jumped into the water to find Celia, who had fallen into the water. They caught the hem of her silver-blue dress beneath the waves, but the whirlpool dragged them both away from the ship. The red mane of Pegasus and the light of Ignis were briefly visible above the water and then obscured by heavy rain.

In the water, Celia was unconscious and did not let go of the green jade staff. Kadan knew that if he threw away the wand, two people could come to mind, but he also knew that it was not Celia's personal belongings, but the trust of the refugees. He first unwrapped his armor and his father's empty sword scabbard and released them into the sea.

Aeolus sent a rescue signal with a flute. Ignis was lying on the deck with its core burned out. Medusa Gorgo could have killed him or taken the codex piece, but instead, he drew a reverse rune that calmed the flame.

As dawn broke, the sea became calm as if it were a lie. The remains of the flower boat covered the water surface like flower petals. Kadan and Celia were nowhere to be seen.

Kadan opened his eyes on the beach of an unnamed island far away. One hand was holding Celia's wrist, and the other hand was holding a piece of the codex entrusted by Gandar. I heard someone stepping on wet sand from inside the forest.

PART III



Sealed Records and a False Wedding

Betrayal Aboard the Burning Ship



The footprints on the beach belonged to Leonar. He rescued a refuge ship and searched for Kadan and Celia, but was pushed by a storm and ended up on the same island. There was a deep black wound on one shoulder. It was a trace of a fight with Death Knight Artus.

Leonar climbed onto Lucian's command ship to rescue refugees, but fell into a trap. Death Knight Artus was an undead knight with no body inside his armor. After channeling the opponent's attack into the empty armor, it left a direct wound on the soul. Even the barrier of the green jade staff could not completely block his sword.

Leonar hid his wounds as if he were bragging. When Celia tried to cut the armor, he found the meat, saying it was fine, and collapsed after one step. As Kadan carried him to the cave on his back, he realized that he too had behaved the same way in the face of danger. Celia glared at the two people alternately and asked, Is the common technique of strong men hindering treatment?

The three people made their home in a coastal cave. Celia washed the wound with herbs and sea salt, and Kadan collected rainwater and dug an ice cellar. It was peaceful during the day, but every night the sound of metal dragging in the forest grew closer.

Death Knight Artus was on the island with Orihalcon. They targeted Kadan's codex pieces. Orihalcon lied and offered a deal, saying he had seen a rescue ship. The condition was that he would take everyone with him if he read the codex.

When Kadan refused, Death Knight Artus awakened the soul fragment planted in Leonar's wound. A black crack spread to my heart. To save Leonar, the sealing key held by Death Knight Artus was needed.

Kadan bought time by pretending to transcribe the codex. He arranged the sentences in reverse order but hid minor errors so as not to overwhelm them immediately after reading them. Celia adjusted the drying speed of the ink with the wind to create different densities between real and fake runes.

Kadan's handwriting was slow, so he almost got caught cheating. Celia deliberately argued with Orihalcon to attract attention. Every time he boasted about his wisdom, he asked a more difficult question and kept people talking all night long. Buying time by fueling the enemy's vanity was a battle that Celia could not imitate.

Orihalcon pushed Kadan's raft into the sea at night to leave Celia alone. It was a twisted calculation that if he was trapped on the island forever, he would rely on himself. When he returned, Celia pretended not to know anything and asked about the rescue boat.

She lured Orihalcon into a trap below the cliff. A pocket of wind hidden between the rocks burst and the ground collapsed, and a huge stone crushed his legs. The tide began to rise.

Leave that person behind. Celia said. He destroyed the raft. He is with the same people who killed Leonar.

Kadan said he would save Orihalcon. Celia's face stiffened. Does your goodness always come before our lives?

The tide rose even as the two men argued. Celia did not wait for Kadan to find the right thing to say. I got angry as I hung a rope on a rock and calculated the rescue angle. Kadan felt even more sorry because he was a person who could separate emotions from what needed to be done.

Kadan could not answer that question right away. Behind my conviction that I was doing the right thing, there were moments when I refused to see the price paid by those close to me. He said, holding Celia's hand.

I will not take lightly the reason you are against it. Still, if you abandon someone who could have been saved right before my eyes, I might blame you for that choice for the rest of my life. I don't want to be that person.

Celia looked at the cracks in the rock without losing his anger. The two used Leonar's staff as a lever and pushed snow and wind into the gap to lift the rock. Orihalcon survived, but had difficulty regaining use of his legs.

Meanwhile, Death Knight Artus left the island with a copy of the codex and the sealing key. Leonar's breathing became shallow. On the horizon was a single burning sail receding away.

Four on a Deserted Island



Only two wounded and two exhausted people remained on the island. Orihalcon laughed at Kadan who saved him. He said that since the key was taken away, Leonar would die, and since there was no raft, everyone would lie in the same grave.

Celia did not respond to his taunts and collected the broken wood. The ebony trees that withstood the wind for a long time were lighter than water, and the spider vines inside the island could be used as ropes. While Kadan was carrying logs, she recorded the movements of birds and stars.

Kadan tried to make the raft square, and Celia said that a long shape to cut through the waves would be better. The two tied the tree three times and then untied it. Leonar was lying down and listening to the two people's argument, and muttered that things made together would only last long if both sides showed a reasonable amount of stubbornness.

Before Leonar lost consciousness, he handed the green jade staff to Celia. The method of lifting the barrier, known only to the leader of the Free People's League, was also shared. A leader is not someone who saves everyone. It is someone who decides who to save first and does not run away from that decision.

Celia would not accept the cane. Leonar did not let go. In the end, when she accepted it with both hands, a wind pattern bloomed on the surface of the green jade.

Three days later the raft was completed. Orihalcon crawled alone in the middle of the night and untied the rope. Kadan caught him, but the tide dragged the

raft away. Celia bent the springy trees on the coast back and made them into giant catapults.

Shoot me.

When Kadan hesitated, she smiled. This time it's my plan, not your recklessness.

Celia flew up from the bent tree and fell into the sea next to the raft. After diving under the water and loosening a few ropes, he swam back to the island without Orihalcon knowing. When the raft went out to sea, it lost its direction and had to ride the current to return.

As expected, the next morning, the nearly broken raft and Orihalcon washed up on the opposite shore. He was afraid of Celia for the first time. Kadan brought him back to life, but this time tied him to the center of the raft.

Orihalcon could not endure hunger and told a story about the time when he worked at the royal court. Lucian required technicians to record failures before finished products. It was a habit of trying to find out how a device that saves people could kill them. Orihalcon took the money and pretended not to know the danger.

Just before departure, two Griffon came down from the sky. The birds sent by Titania delivered Kadan's letter and searched the sea without returning. One of them was holding a short scorpion from Ignis along with a sealing key.

I chased down Death Knight Artus and recovered the key. Pay off a debt.

When the key was placed on Leonar's wound, a piece of black soul came out. Kadan trapped the pieces with snow crystals, and Celia blew them away out to sea with the wind. Leonar woke up from a long sleep and the first thing he said was to look for something to eat.

The four people boarded a small raft. Orihalcon was a prisoner and Leonar could not move. There was only enough drinking water for five days.

Nevertheless, Leonar took out alcohol made from fermented coconut and gave everyone a sip.

A glass of wine also went to Orihalcon. Celia was against it, but Leonar said that if you do not treat prisoners like human beings, the words you hear during interrogation will not be human words. Even after Orihalcon took the glass, he could not put it to his mouth for a while.

Celia said to Kadan that he was still angry. Kadan did not urge him to let go of his anger. The two grabbed the same oar without fully understanding each other's choices. Every time a wave came, the backs of our hands hit each other, and at some point, we started rowing at the same beat, no matter who went first.

On the evening of the third day, lights on land appeared. That was the coast of Elwin village, where all the tragedy began. Death Knight Artus's artificial flames were flashing beneath the ruins.

The Record Sleeping in the Cave



Elwin The village was frozen as it was the day it was burned. Underneath the collapsed tavern, there was an underground passage that neither Aleksandar nor Balian knew about. Lucian and Death Knight Artus were digging through the ruins to find the strategic core left behind by the kingdom's war hero, Ironforge.

The core of Ironforge recorded not only the tactics of protecting a single castle wall, but also the continent's ley lines, supply routes, and a refuge network for moving civilians. If Lucian got his hands on it, he could destroy Wildland and Lighthaven at the same time.

Residents of the ruins believed the treasure was gold or weapons. Kadan wondered if telling the truth would put people in more danger, but Celia said the residents needed to know what was beneath their village. Before entering the cave, they held a village meeting to explain the risks and options. Instead of running away, residents took over guarding the exit.

Kadan and the party entered the cave with Orihalcon as their guide. A long time ago, while working as a royal engineer, he created a magnetic device for the entrance. Celia knew he would cheat again, so he put wind marks on both sleeves. When the heart beats faster while lying, the sign makes a whistle.

The inside of the cave was not a tomb, but a huge mock battlefield. Thousands of stone soldiers moved according to the invaders' choices. Every time Kadan chose to attack head-on, the refugee model fell first.

In the first mock battle, Kadan was declared defeated even after defeating the enemy commander. This is because one stone child was left behind in the

evacuation procession. The second time, we lost our supply route while waiting for everyone. Celia found small letters on the edge of the device, saying he had to read the victory conditions themselves.

This is not a test to find a strong commander. Celia said. It s a test to find a way to get someone out without a fight.

She opened the old aqueduct and sent an alarm to the other side with the wind. Kadan drew back the stone soldier's attack with his shield, and Leonar marked the retreat route with his green jade staff. When the three people divided up their roles, the door to the mock battlefield opened for the first time.

There was a black stone box in the center. The lid was engraved with the phrase, Count those who survive before you win. When Kadan touched it, his father's dagger and stone chest resonated. Aleksandar was one of the people who hid Ironforge's last messenger.

The strategic core inside the stone box was not a crystal sphere but hundreds of thin metal leaves. Each chapter contained memories from a different region, so removing one changed the entire strategy. Celia argued that it should be distributed and stored like a codex.

Death Knight Artus came through the wall. A black wind swirled through his empty armor. Kadan's attack passed through without finding the body, and Leonar's barrier was cut off by the soul sword.

Orihalcon was able to escape, but activated the stone box's magnetic device. Death Knight Artus's armor stuck to the wall and its movement stopped. He laughed and said he had become a hero, but he knew better than anyone else that the device would not last long.

When Kadan tried to stay together, Orihalcon was the first to swear harshly. If you want to brag about saving me for the rest of your life, don t die here with me. Celia grabbed Kadan by the collar and dragged him into the aisle. It was a face that did not want to make anyone's sacrifice a romantic ending.

Celia divided the metal leaves into three bundles. Leonar was in charge of the refuge net, Kadan was in charge of defensive tactics, and he was in charge of the ley line map. The last one was handed to Orihalcon. You protect it as proof that this choice was not a trick.

Those words silenced Orihalcon's bravado. He placed the metal leaf inside the armor and held onto Death Knight Artus's magnetic device until the end. The moment everyone exited the passage, the device exploded and half the cave collapsed.

Death Knight Artus rose from the rubble but was unable to obtain the entire strategic core. Outside the ruins, Kadan realized that what his father was trying to protect was not a family or revenge, but an escape route for ordinary people.

Seven Nights in the Sealed Chamber



When the cave collapsed, Death Knight Artus's soul sword pierced Kadan's waist. It was a small wound on the outside, but black cold spread into the mana core. Neither Leonar's detoxification nor Celia's wind healing could remove the blade lodged in the soul.

Celia found a secret sealed room in the kitchen of a collapsed tavern. In the past, it was a space where Aleksandar hid messengers. Inside, there remained a star rune that blocked external mana. Kadan was able to force the soul sword to push itself away without allowing it to consume the new power.

Conditions were harsh. For seven nights, the two people had to hold their palms together and not cut off the flow of mana. If it falls even once, the blade moves to the heart. Celia closed the seal door without hesitation.

On the first day, Kadan was excited and called out the names of his father and Balian. On the second day, he laughed and told Ignis that he was a better son. The arrogance hidden beneath consciousness flowed out along with venom.

Celia wrote in a small notebook what Kadan would normally have hidden. I muttered that it was to tease him later, but in reality, I was afraid he wouldn't remember any of his fears after the fever passed. Kadan apologized countless times in his sleep for disappointing his teachers.

Celia did not cover it with pleasant words. You weren't always right. There were times when you ignored my choices in the name of saving people. So, come back to life and apologize in person.

On the third day, Kadan's pulse stopped. Celia forcibly connected his wind core to his chest. As the two people's memories were mixed, Kadan saw the night Celia was eating alone in an empty mansion as a child, and Celia saw Kadan crying on a cliff because he could not live up to his teachers' expectations.

Memories do not only select beautiful scenes. Celia saw a moment when he secretly ignored Kadan's simplicity, and a time when Kadan relied on Celia's plan but accepted the ball as if it were his own choice. In a room where they couldn't let go of each other, the two faced each other, both the ways they loved each other and the ways they turned away from each other.

People gathered outside. Ignis came to the ruins in pursuit of Death Knight Artus, and the six teachers and Hercul also heard the news of Kadan. Rondol and Eliana from the Cloud Return Mansion, and Gilgamesh from the north arrived at Elwin by different routes.

The first conflict occurred between people who did not trust each other. Grimli tried to keep Ignis away from the sealing room, and Ignis countered that only the flashback rune he brought could save Kadan. Hercul stood between the two and reminded Balian's last request.

On the fifth night, the air in the sealing room ran out. Instead of opening the door, Celia shaped the remaining wind into a thin tube and sent it to Kadan first. He took a short breath and came to his senses.

On the sixth night, Ignis activated the backfire rune outside the door. Using the forbidden liquor left in his core as bait, he pulled out Death Knight Artus's soul fragment from Kadan. Black cold passed through the sealed door and attached to Ignis's arm.

Grimli held Ignis's shoulders and shared mana. He was the person who usually didn't trust him the most. This does not make past mistakes go away. Ignis gritted his teeth and answered that he knew. But do what you have to do now. Hearing Grimli's words, the rest of the teachers also placed their hands.

Celia called his name from inside. Stop, if you die, do you think Kadan will accept this as salvation?

Ignis reduced power. Instead of the easy ending of dying for everyone, I chose the difficult path of sharing the pain and surviving. Hercul and the six masters shared the rest of Rune's burden.

On the seventh dawn, Kadan opened his eyes. The first thing he said was that Celia's hands were cold. Celia couldn't laugh or cry and hit his forehead.

When the sealed door opened, the people gathered in the ruins exhaled at the same time. But the joy was short-lived. A piece of the strategic core protected by Orihalcon disappeared, and a piece of Lucian's red glass fell on the floor.

Night of the False Wedding



While Kadan was recovering, an unexpected wedding was held in the ruins of Elwin. Rondol of the Cloud Return Mansion knew that his son Kaze and the pharmacist Eliana had been in love for a long time, so he allowed the two to unite. The feast began with raising the beams of the collapsed tavern.

Celia hung a wind lamp on the ruins, and Gilgamesh opened the northern barrel. Kadan was kicked out three times while carrying a chair with his waist bandaged. Everyone devoted themselves to work with the intention of enjoying ordinary joy, even if only for a moment.

Eliana wore a pharmacist's apron instead of a wedding gown. The reason was that if an injury occurs, it must be treated immediately. Kaze lost the ring and searched the kitchen and the well until just before the ceremony. Grimli had tied the ring to his beard as a joke.

Ignis kept the fire outside the feast. People were wary of him and children hid when they saw the white flames. When Kadan approached him with a glass of wine, he said that he had no right to smile after his parents' funeral.

A child came close to the campfire because of the cold. Ignis lowered the color of the white flame to orange so that the child would not be scared. The fire stirred clumsily, but it was warm. After the child warmed his hands and returned, Ignis paused for a long time, realizing that he had never learned how to make such a small fire.

If you needed qualifications to smile, all the banquets in the world would be empty. Kadan left the drink next to him and went back. After a while, Ignis emptied his glass alone.

The night after the wedding, Orihalcon appeared in front of the secret sealing room. Since he could not use his legs, he was supporting his body with a metal brace. He claimed that he never stole the Strategic Core and that Lucian cut his memories.

Celia checked his wind signature. The heart beat was fast, but the whistle of lies did not sound. Someone had changed the memory itself to hide the truth while telling the truth.

A small crystal bug was discovered inside Orihalcon's auxiliary sphere. It was a surveillance device made from fragments of Death Knight Artus's armor. As Ignis melted the shell with flames, the crystal bug played Lucian's voice.

Orihalcon described the feeling of having an empty room in his memory. When I thought of a certain name, it seemed to go to the door and then slip away. Celia did not force the memories open with the wind. Forcibly recovering memories for which one was not prepared was another intrusion.

After the wedding, Kadan and the party will head to the southern imperial palace. Let them get the last chapter of the core themselves.

The missing metal leaf was not a map but a key. When all the remaining cores are stacked, the Ironforge tactical room in the basement of the imperial palace opens, where the original device that moves the ley lines of the entire continent lies dormant.

Kadan said they had to go to the imperial palace even though they knew that Lucian was leading them. If the original device was left untouched, the Court of Red Glass would find it someday. Celia said to go into the trap but not to move in the order the opponent expected.

Ignis proposed that he would return to the palace first and commit a false defection. Lucian still believes he wants the throne. The calculation was that the security network could be changed from within.

Grimli opposed. He who is best at betrayal is also the best at spies.

Ignis was not angry. That s true. That s why we need to decide how to monitor me as well.

Celia planted a wind mark on Ignis's flame. If he voluntarily harms someone to Lucian, the mark will turn off and the crystal held by Kadan will be broken. Instead of demanding trust in words, the cost of betrayal was made visible.

The next day, the three people took different paths to the imperial palace. Kadan joined the refugee caravan with his six teachers, and Celia rode the Freeman's League's contact network. Ignis put on his red glass cloak again. The wedding wind lamps were going out one by one in the daylight.

Open Door, Closed Heart



Ignis returned to the Red Glass Court and knelt before Lucian. Although he was momentarily shaken by the death of his parents, he eventually lied and said that the position of prince suited him. Lucian accepted him even though he was skeptical. This is because a symbol that deals with white flames was needed for the court ahead of war.

For the first few days, Ignis went as planned. Changed the underground guard's shift time and told Celia about the secret passage. However, the old rooms, formal clothes, and people bowing to themselves brought back a sense of the past faster than expected.

The servants said that they cleaned the room every day even while Ignis was gone. In the closet, new formal clothes were prepared for each season. Although it seemed like Lucian's consideration, it was actually a quiet order to return at any time and wear the same robe. Ignis was unable to burn his robes and only smoothed the collar with his fingertips.

Lucian did not promise to put him on the throne. Instead, he whispered, If Kadan saves the world, people will make him king. It was the possibility that Ignis feared the most but could not admit.

Meanwhile, Kadan arrived in front of the Ironforge tactical room in the basement of the imperial palace. When three bundles of metal leaves were placed on top of the door, a complex ley line map appeared. But the last key was missing. The missing chapter from Orihalcon was needed.

Celia read the dust in the wind around the door. There were signs that someone had already opened and closed the door from the inside. The person who stole

the key was most likely Ignis, not Lucian.

Ignis's characteristic right foot drag remained on the floor. It was a habit I had after injuring my ankle during flame training when I was young. Kadan squatted in front of the trace and was silent for a while. I tried to stop the habit of trying to erase something between the words I believe and the evidence I can see.

Kadan did not immediately suspect him. That attitude actually made Celia anxious. Trust is not about not seeing the evidence.

At that time, the Star Sanctuary knights and Aeolus encountered each other in the underground passage. Death Knight Artus sent different secret messages to both sides to induce battle. Hercul believed that Aeolus had kidnapped Kadan, and Aeolus thought that the Holy Knights had come to steal the codex.

Death Knight Artus swung his soul sword in the darkness. The attack was aimed at Aeolus's back, but Medusa Gorgo was hit instead. The body damaged by the forbidden liquor quickly collapsed in the black light.

Aeolus hugged his fallen disciple. Medusa Gorgo neither asked for nor forgave. However, he said that Belphegor sent him alive at the end, and told his teacher to live to see the next story of his mistakes.

When Medusa Gorgo touched Aeolus's hand, he initially pushed it away. But at the end, he grabbed his sleeve and asked where Belphegor was buried. After hearing the answer that there was no exact grave, he asked them to scatter the pieces of the welcome stone where the two laughed in the same sea.

The misunderstanding was resolved before her death. Hercul and Aeolus attacked Death Knight Artus, but the empty armor disappeared into the dark passage. The last metal leaf and the flame mark of Ignis remained on the floor.

When the tactical room door opened, the ley line device inside was awakened. The mountain ranges and rivers of the continent emerged as miniature models of light. Lucian had already replicated the northern invasion route, but the core

of the civilian refuge network was still safe.

The crystal of Celia was slightly cracked. It meant that Ignis had harmed someone. Since it wasn't completely broken, it didn't take his life.

Kadan looked up above the palace. Ignis's closed mind was more dangerous than the open tactical room. He has now accepted that trusting his friend and preventing his friend from making mistakes are equal responsibilities.

Between Two Promises



Titania and Gilgamesh led the Wildland delegation and arrived near the imperial palace. Fenrir requested his daughter's marriage to Kadan as a condition of forming an alliance with Lighthaven. The personal promise returned as a war treaty.

Titania met Kadan separately before the official meeting. She said she cried for three days after reading Kadan's letter, and then tore up her father's order.

Kadan did not prepare a gift to return to Titania. I only untied the red string that I had been holding for a long time and handed it over. Titania said it was better than expensive jewels. The return of the item was a clear sign that the promise had ended.

I'm more angry that you gave me something as a reward without me having a chance to refuse it, than that you don't love me.

Kadan apologized without making excuses. I didn't ask about Titania's current feelings because I thought I had to keep the promise I made when I was young. Titania asked for the red string back. When Kadan unwrapped the dagger and handed it to her, she tied it to her bow.

Now I will decide which way to return.

Celia watched the conversation between the two from afar and left. Titania came to her first. There were no pretense of friendly words between the two. Titania warned that Kadan trusted people enough to be dangerous, and Celia responded that he already knew.

Titania asked if Kadan had ever noticed before him when he was sick. Celia honestly answered that he missed it twice. The two laughed for a moment. Instead of competing for love, a strange alliance emerged where each person shared what they knew about one person's weaknesses.

Ignis appeared at the conference hall wearing the prince's robes. He declared himself the successor to Lucian and promised the Wildlands and the Freeman's League the protection of his court. As Kadan approached, the crystal gold increased by one more line.

Did you take the last metal leaf?

I didn't take it, but I took back what originally belonged to my kingdom.

Ignis's voice was as arrogant as it was on the duel table long ago. But Kadan saw burns on the inside of the wrist and irregular breathing. Ignis was using the power of banned alcohol again.

Lucian activated the mana bomb hidden on the ceiling of the conference room. They planned to kill the representatives of Wildland and Lighthaven at the same time to blame each other. Ignis knew about the bomb, but did not announce it until the last moment for fear of losing his chance to win the throne.

He drew and erased the bomb disarm rune three times before the meeting. The calculation was that if Lucian caught him, he would never be able to move within the palace again. Amid the hesitation that seemed reasonable, there was also a desire that did not give up the possibility that only he would survive the explosion and become king.

Just before the explosion, Titania moved the Griffon cavalry to tear off the roof, and Celia sent the heat into the sky. Kadan broke the central rune with Dragon Breaker. Ignis also burned the remaining fragments with white flames.

People cheered that he had saved everyone, but Ignis did not reveal that he had been silent. When Kadan tried to speak on his behalf, Celia did not stop him. I

couldn't lie to the victims because I was protecting my friend's honor.

When the truth was revealed, the conference room turned upside down with anger. Ignis rushed towards Kadan. You always stand on the right side and look down on me.

No. I believed you would come back, so I stopped you too late.

Their fire and eyes collided again. This time it was not a duel of skills. Kadan took Ignis's attack and broke only the forbidden art runes one by one. Ignis was unable to land a critical blow and retreated with the palace soldiers.

Fenrir's alliance was on the verge of collapse. Titania declared that he would remain based on his own judgment instead of his father's orders. I will fight not for the throne of Lighthaven, but for the people under the bomb.

Kadan belatedly understood that he had not lost both of his promises, but had released them from their promise. But the pledge with Ignis is not over yet. The last chance to get him out was closing fast.

Revolt of the Jade Council



The Great Council of the Freeman's League was held beneath the Iron Palm Mountains. After Leonar stepped down due to injury, it was a place to decide on a new owner for the green jade staff and which side to stand on in the coming war. Thousands of tents filled the valley.

Celia did not want to be the leader even if he held a cane. However, the representatives of each region distrusted her because she was an aristocrat of Wind Island. Ignis dug into that gap. He gathered support by distributing food to the refugees and sharing gold from the palace treasury.

The gratitude of those who received the food was not false. Ignis actually fed a starving child and opened a corrupt warehouse. The problem was calculating those good deeds in terms of votes and loyalty. He believed in establishing order himself while turning people's gratitude into steps to the throne.

Ignis did not intend to hand over the federation to Lucian. Rather, he believed that if he served as both king and chief, no one could abandon the people. It was the old court logic that if the purpose was right, the power taken away was also justifiable.

Kadan visited him on the eve of the Congress and returned the wooden horse. Ignis saw signs of repairing the wheel and asked if Kadan had touched it. Kadan replied that it was a part that Ignis fixed himself. I had repaired it without realizing it on a drunken night and couldn't remember it.

Your hands don't just remember what you break.

Ignis was shaken, but headed to the podium with the wooden horse in his arms.

Lucian gave him a fake green jade staff and Leonar's fabricated will. Ignis went up to the podium even though he knew it was false. I fooled myself into thinking that once I was called king in front of the crowd, I would have a chance to set the truth straight.

Celia did not claim forgery in words alone. By sticking a real staff into the ground, he revealed all of the Federation's old escape routes. On each path, the names of the people Leonar had personally saved appeared. The authority of the head came not from the crown, but from the record of lives preserved.

Ignis tried to cover the record with white flames. Celia's crystal finally shattered. One refugee collapsed in the flames, and Kadan saved him with his shield.

Kadan and Ignis stood face to face for the last time in the center of parliament. Ignis shouted that Kadan had everything. Mother's love, teacher, Celia, people's faith. All he has left is the throne he took from himself.

I'm only looking at what I have, so I can't see what you threw away. Kadan's voice trembled. We were there for you too.

Ignis unleashed the final rune of the forbidden art. The mana of the people around me was sucked into the white flame. Kadan did not attack, but created hundreds of thin shields through binary division, severing the connection between people and the flame one by one.

The runes that had lost their power flowed back. Black cracks started from Ignis's fingernails and spread up his arms and neck. It was a self-destruct device that Lucian had installed from the beginning. Even if he took the throne, he was prevented from coming down alive.

Celia drew the reverse rune, but Ignis had taken too much life. Kadan hugged his friend and tried to connect his core. Ignis pushed his hand away.

Don't save me again and use it as proof that you were right.

You don't need any evidence. You have to live and apologize yourself.

Ignis smiled faintly. I remembered hearing the same thing outside the sealing room. He sent the remaining flames back to the people. One by one, the extinguished lamps in the valley came to life, and the warmth drained from his body.

At the last moment, Ignis called Kadan brother. I asked Celia not to turn the staff into a crown. And he asked not to bury himself in his parents' grave. The reason was that I had not yet earned the right to lie next to them.

Kadan was angry that he was not the one who decided the qualifications. Ignis didn't have the strength to answer, so he just smiled with his eyes. One wheel of the wooden horse slowly spun and stopped in the white flames.

The white flame left no ash. Only a small spark that hardened like glass fell on the platform. Kadan held it in his hand and could not move for a long time. No one in the crowd shouted the new leader's name.

Queen of the Wind



The day after Ignis's death, the Freedmen's League held another congress. Celia did not prepare black robes or a memorial speech. Instead, I started by reading the names of those who had been injured the day before, the medicine needed, and the amount of food lost.

The representatives entrusted the position of leader to her, who held a green jade staff. Celia put a condition on it. The conditions were that the head would not be inherited by blood, that he would step down immediately if three or more regions voted against him, and that an evacuation plan must be attached to every wartime order.

Representatives objected, saying it would weaken their authority too much. Celia reminded Ignis that an organization where one person can make decisions quickly put Ignis on the stage. Both the costs of slow agreement and the costs of fast dictatorship had to be put on the books.

Don't call me queen, because the wind doesn't sit on the throne.

Nevertheless, people called her the Queen of the Winds. A name mixed with respect and expectations was sometimes heavier than shackles.

The first mission was to find traitors within the Federation. Lucian's gold was flowing to various representatives, and fake orders were leading refugees into a dead-end valley in the Iron Palm Mountains.

Celia took off his chief's attire and put on the clothes of a beggar from Zhangjiagou Market again. Kadan pretended not to recognize her, just like when they first met, but he couldn't hide his smile. The two joined the refugee

procession and chased after the fake guides.

The traitors spread a rumor that Kadan killed Ignis. Angry refugees surrounded Kadan. He did not draw his sword and told exactly what he had done in the last battle. I stopped Ignis, tried to save him, and failed.

One woman said her child survived on food released by Ignis. Another man lost his brother to Prohibition. Kadan did not refute any of the memories. Loving or hating a person did not erase the other consequences he left behind.

Instead of defending Kadan, Celia showed the field record crystal ball. The right to judge the facts was returned to the crowd. After being silent for a long time, people opened the way.

The traitors' home base was an abandoned smelter midway up the mountain range. A fake elder claiming to be Orihalcon's older brother gathered followers by demonstrating the miracle of melting steel with his bare hands. Celia found a firestone pipe hidden under the heat source.

When his identity was revealed, the fake Grand Elder used the real Iron Palm shock technique. His compression wave hit Celia's back, shattering his windscale armor from the inside. Even as she fell, she opened an escape passage with her green jade staff.

Kadan did not chase the enemy, but carried Celia. If he were his old self, he would have tried not to miss the villain. Now I know that it is my responsibility to decide who to save first and deal with the consequences.

Before Celia lost consciousness, he ordered the fake Grand Elder to be let go. Kadan also told me not to pretend to be my own judgement and to leave a record of following orders. This was meant to ensure that the path of responsibility does not disappear even if the leader falls.

Celia stole the map from the fake Grand Elder's waist before losing consciousness. The map showed four gateways across the mountain range and the sanctuary of Aqualord hidden at the end of them. He who manipulated life

mana could repair the broken wind core.

Kadan tied the green jade staff to his back and picked up Celia. Federation representatives followed suit, saying they would protect the leader, but he only allowed the minimum number of people. A large army only irritated the gateway.

That night, Ignis's glass spark shined once in Kadan's pocket. A thin flame tilted toward the south, as if indicating the remaining path.

Poison at the Four Gates



There were four gates on the way to the sanctuary of Aqualord. The first was guarded by a fisherman below the waterfall. He blocked the passage of Kadan for scaring the golden scale fish. As time passed, Celia's breathing became shallower.

Kadan did not snatch the fishing rod by force. By using ice to slow down just one line of water, we helped the fish take the bait on their own. The fisherman released the fish he had caught and opened the way. People who are in a hurry tend to stir the water more, but you know how to wait.

While waiting, Celia's fever rose even more. Kadan thought about ignoring the gateway test several times. Celia grabbed his collar while unconscious and muttered, If you start by pointing a knife into someone else's sanctuary, I will wake up and scold you.

At the second gate, a woodcutter was moving a large fallen tree by himself. When Kadan tried to help, the woodcutter refused to help. The problem was not strength, but pulling out the young spirit trapped under the giant tree without harming it. Celia announced the position of the wind in a faint voice, and Kadan split the binary star to support the weight of each side differently.

The farmer at the third gate showed a dry field and asked Celia to choose whether to sweep or pour a bottle of water onto the field. Kadan did not split the bottle in half. After just wetting Celia's lips, I poured the remaining water into the seeds. When the farmer tapped the ground with his foot, groundwater rose and both of them quenched their thirst.

Kadan began to see that the test was to see whether people doubted the conditions in front of them rather than their goodness. No one said there was only one bottle of water. He first checked the moisture in the field and the underground noise. The senses taught by the teachers were more useful in moments like this than in fighting.

Scholar Sylvania waited at the final gate. He asked what was heavier: one life or a thousand people.

Kadan did not embellish his answer. Right now, the one person on my back is the heaviest. But I will not choose to put a thousand people in danger to save that person. If there is someone who created a situation where I have to compare the two, I will break that false condition first.

Sylvania warned while opening the way. Aqualord was once a king and was able to save a child, but he turned away and abandoned the throne to prevent war. He said that even now he does not meet anyone who asks for healing.

A maze of poisonous fog spread out in the forest just before the sanctuary. The pursuers sent by the fake Grand Elder blocked the road and demanded that Celia be handed over. They said that if the leader died, the League of Freemen would deal with the court again.

Kadan fought without putting down Celia. The enemy's position was changed by stepping rather than attacking, and the poisonous fog was carried by the wind and guided back towards the pursuer. Even though Celia was unconscious, he pointed in the direction three times with his finger.

After the last enemy retreated, Kadan's knees buckled. He drank too much poison, but with the star breathing he learned from Malfuon, he only had air left around his heart. The white door of the sanctuary was right in front.

The door didn't open. Kadan laid Celia in front of the door without knocking or breaking it, and then sat down next to him.

He talked to Celia at the door about the past until night fell. From the day we first shared soup to the last flame of Ignis, he did not ask the unconscious person for answers, but only made his voice heard. Celia's fingers moved once, but his eyes did not open.

If you've heard why we've come here, judge for yourself, but if you're going to say no, say it to my face, not keep silent behind closed doors.

After a long time, the sound of flowing water changed. The white door opened inward, and Aqualord wearing a blue robe appeared. His first gaze was not on Celia, but on the glowing ember of Ignis in Kadan's pocket.

PART IV



The Conqueror's War and the Final Name

The Hand That Wagered Everything



Aqualord placed his hand on Celia's chest and examined the broken wind core. He said he could be saved, but at a high cost. If you transfer half of your life mana, you will not be able to use healing arts for at least five years, and if enemies from long ago come to visit you, you will lose the power to protect the sanctuary.

Kadan said he would give up mana instead. Aqualord shook his head. Even though Kadan's frost core could suture wounds, it could not revive the beat of the wind.

Aqualord had Kadan watch the healing. It meant breaking the habit of saying that you would sacrifice yourself to avoid seeing your loved one suffer. Every time Kadan's fingers trembled, Kadan stood up and sat down again.

Paying the price for a choice is not always a sacrifice. Sometimes it also means taking away the other person's right to decide.

Aqualord woke up Celia, who was faintly conscious, and asked him directly. After surviving, will he return to the Freeman's League's war and his own responsibilities, or will he stop here without suffering? Celia barely moved his lips.

I haven't been able to return the wand yet.

The healing began at sunset and lasted until noon the next day. From Aqualord's fingertips, a watery pattern flowed along Celia's veins, while Kadan held onto the ley line with the four gate guardians outside.

In Celia's memories, the wind swirled around the sanctuary. The smell of bread from Janggagu Market, the song of Sylphid heard on Wind Island, and the hot ashes left by Ignis shook the doors and windows one after another. Aqualord did not cut out any memories and let the core find its own beat.

The moment Celia's core started beating again, Aqualord vomited blood and collapsed. His hair became as white as snow. As soon as Celia opened his eyes, he realized that a person had lost years of life because of him.

Don't end with just saying thank you. Aqualord smiled. If you want to make my choice valuable, next time you ask and listen to someone else's choice.

That night, poison was found in a vial in the sanctuary. It was placed by a woman named Naiad in the pocket of Sylvania, who guided the four gateways. The poison was not aimed at Celia, but at Aqualord, which had completed healing.

Naiad was a court mage who read the stars in the kingdom of Aqualord a long time ago. She fell in love with Gandar and gave birth to Aquaris, but Aqualord, fearing for the kingdom's reputation, separated them. Even when Aquaris was mortally wounded in an attack by Death Knight Artus, he refused to be healed for fear of breaking his neutrality in the war.

Even after Aqualord drank the poison, he did not look for an antidote first. It was only when he heard that Naiad had used Celia's life to lure him here that his face shook. He said she needed to know that her revenge had made others the same victims.

Aqualord made no excuses. In the name of protecting a country, he ignored Aquaris's life, and from that day on, he abandoned the throne. Naiad believed that punishing himself was not enough.

Celia separated the components of the poison with wind. While saving Aqualord, it left behind a scent that could trace Naiad's whereabouts. Kadan

said that the cycle of revenge must be prevented from starting again.

Aqualord looked at Ignis's spark and found out that other life mana was mixed within it. Some of the power that Ignis sent back at the end could not find its owner and remained in the embers. That power was later able to hold the core of a dying person once.

When Kadan heard those words, he squeezed the embers harder. The fact that I had to decide when and on whom to use the power left behind after my friend died added another layer of weight.

Echo of First Love



The place where I found Naiad was a small house at the edge of the black swamp. The walls were filled with constellations and water flows calculated over decades, and letters that had never been sent were piled up on the table. All letters were addressed to Gandar.

When she saw Kadan and Celia, she admitted that she had poisoned them. Knowing that Aqualord would lose his strength if he treated Celia, he deliberately sent two people to the sanctuary. It was as if Celia's life was put into the calculation for revenge.

Naiad did not apologize. Instead of forcing an apology, Aqualord accurately told the story of the pain he had experienced and the strength Aqualord had lost during the healing process. It was a choice to make people see the human body hidden behind abstract revenge.

Celia was angry, but before condemning Naiad, he asked about Aquaris's death. Naiad took out a piece of old cloth. Blood stains remained under the embroidery of two water birds flying side by side.

Gandar stayed in the sanctuary when he was young and met Naiad. He only loved pranks and running away, so he left the kingdom because he was afraid that he was in love with someone. Naiad gave birth to Aquaris alone, and ran to Aqualord holding Aquaris, who had been injured by Death Knight Artus's soul sword.

Aqualord refused on the grounds that if Aquaris was saved, the kingdom's ley defenses would be turned off for a day. Thousands of people could die that day. He thought he had made the right decision as king, but after Aquaris passed

away, he realized that neither life should be left as a number.

If you realize it, will my Aquaris come back? Naiad asked.

No. Celia answered. So you don't have to forgive, but if you put someone else in the same calculation, you're repeating the choices you hated.

Naiad saw a familiar light in Celia's eyes. When I was young, I believed in my own judgment rather than someone else's orders. The years of revenge only dimmed that light.

Gandar showed up at home late. After being released from Aeolus's temple, I was looking for Naiad, but I couldn't come in at the door. When Kadan pushed his back, he fell like a child and entered the room.

Gandar took out half of the piece of cloth he had received a long time ago. I lied and said I threw it away the day I ran away, but I kept it sewn into my sleeve for decades. Naiad said that keeping records is not evidence of fulfillment of responsibility. For the first time, Gandar did not pass it off as a joke and nodded.

Naiad neither hit him nor hugged him. The first question was why did you leave? Gandar admitted that he ran away not because he loved freedom, but because he was not confident in taking responsibility. Underneath the mask of being a funny old man, there was the most cowardly memory.

The two talked all night. The time lost was not made up and my first love did not return to its former self. When dawn came, Naiad handed the pile of letters to Gandar without burning them. The responsibility for reading has been returned.

It took Gandar an hour to read the first letter. I looked out the window every time as if I wanted to run away, but I didn't leave. Naiad made new cups of tea, one cup at a time, until he finished reading. Something slower and less beautiful than reconciliation began between them.

The real reason why Death Knight Artus attacked Aquaris was also revealed. Aquaris's bloodline had a rare resonance that stabilized ley lines, and Lucian later stole that power to create artificial flames. The forbidden arts implanted in Ignis also began with that research.

The glass embers throbbed hotly in Kadan's hands. Ignis's tragedy was planned on top of Aquaris's death even before birth. Naiad touched the embers and sang Aquaris's favorite star song. A tiny bit of water flickered once in the flame.

Grudge of the Black Marsh



Naiad did not give up on revenge. However, the target has changed. Instead of killing Aqualord, he went deep into the black swamp to find Death Knight Artus, who had taken Aquaris's life force. Gandar followed her without saying a word.

Kadan and Celia also went together. Death Knight Artus was injecting artificial souls into armor in a lung laboratory beneath the swamp. On the wall, the mana waveforms of Aquaris, Ignis, and numerous nameless test subjects were hung like samples.

Celia gave each specimen a temporary name. The name was created based on the rooms and the order in which they were discovered, but the intention was not to leave them as numbers. Kadan took off the metal plates one by one and put them into his backpack. Even after the enemy was defeated, it remained to reveal who had been sacrificed.

When Naiad saw Aquaris's waveform, he forgot all calculations and rushed forward. Death Knight Artus waited for that anger. The soul sword used strong emotions as a conduit to invade the opponent's memories. Naiad ended up seeing the night Aquaris died over and over again.

Gandar tried to pull her away, but he was also trapped in the same memory. The possibility that things would have been different if he had not left, the life that Aquaris might have called his father unfolded as an illusion.

Celia used the green jade staff to sever the connection between the two people's emotions and Death Knight Artus. Instead of attacking the armor, Kadan destroyed the soul storage tube on the lab floor. Nameless lights came out all at

once and went up to the swamp.

Death Knight Artus's armor began to empty. He has maintained his body through hundreds of souls. As Kadan released them one by one, the movement became slower.

In the last storage tube, there was a resonance left by Aquaris. She tried to put it into her body. If Aqualord said it, Aquaris's voice could be heard even for a moment.

The reservoir was ready to produce the voice that Naiad most wanted to hear. It was not a real memory, but a device that simulated sadness. Even if Celia found out about it, he did not immediately destroy it. In order not to lose the choice, I explained the structure to Naiad and waited.

Gandar held his hand. Don't lock Aquaris inside you again just because we want to see you.

Naiad held the storage tube in his arms for a long time and then opened the lid. The water-colored resonance rose into the sky and circled around the two. There were no words or faces, but a warm presence touched the back of my hand for a moment.

Death Knight Artus escaped and flooded the laboratory. Celia created wind bubbles to protect everyone's breath, and Kadan escaped carrying the last storage tubes on his shoulder. I could have finished it by pursuing the enemy, but I saved the trapped soul first.

Outside the swamp, Naiad wrote a letter to Aqualord. There was no word of forgiveness. It was said that he had poisoned himself and that he would stay alive and see what he did.

At the end of the letter, the name Aquaris was written for the first time. During my revenge, I hid my name out of fear that I would become weak if I spoke of it. Gandar folded the letter without reading the name out loud. I decided to wait until Naiad spoke.

Gandar did not declare that he would remain by her side. I just asked if I wanted to walk together the next day. Instead of answering, Naiad put half of his luggage on his back.

The records obtained from the research center indicated that the next attack target was Whisper of the Wind Island. Death Knight Artus attempted to take over the entire continent's communication network using Aeolus's sound runes. Kadan and Celia headed toward the eastern sea without any time to recover.

The Fallen Wind Isle



Whisper of the Wind Island no longer hides behind the fog. All the barrier towers had collapsed and the forest was burned black. The trail, which was always changing, became straight like a dead snake.

As soon as Celia landed on the beach, he ran, calling people's names. Instead of answering, only the broken wind chime bell rang. Most of the island's residents retreated to underground shelters, but traces of those who guarded the barrier remained everywhere.

In the central garden, Kadan found Grimli's hammer. The silver bell of Robinyard was still attached to the handle. Going a little further, Aila the Demon Hunter's crossbow, Kaze's sword, and Rondol's oar were laid out one after another.

The weapons weren't dropped randomly. Grimli's hammer was supporting the entrance to the shelter, and Aila the Demon Hunter's last arrow pointed in the opposite direction from where the children fled. Kaze's knife was stuck with the alarm cord cut. Teachers created someone's path until the moment they died.

The six masters arrived on the island first, chasing Death Knight Artus's army. Only Gawain survived with fatal injuries. He heard Kadan's footsteps with his invisible eyes and stretched out his hand.

It s not too late. We just got here first.

Gawain said the attacker used Aeolus's flute sound. In the black fog, it was impossible to tell who was real, and the comrades fell one by one while

protecting each other. At the last moment, I even saw the figure of Aeolus directly wielding the soul sword.

He said that Grimli raised his shield at the end, imitating Kadan's posture. He was a person who always found his student's defense frustrating. Aila the Demon Hunter used his crossbow like a club after running out of arrows, and even at the last moment, Kaze left funny graffiti on the enemy's armor.

Kadan knelt before the weapons of his teachers. No tears came out. All I could think about was what kind of curse Grimli would have sworn at the end and how many shots Aila the Demon Hunter had left.

Aeolus emerged from the ruins of the temple. There was blood on the clothes and the flute. He said everyone was already passed out when he arrived. Kadan wanted to believe it, but Gawain's testimony and traces of the flute were right in front of him.

Celia approached his father and asked for the flute. The moment Aeolus hesitated for a moment, Kadan accepted the movement as evidence of guilt. The impact of the Dragon Breaker split the garden floor.

Aeolus did not counterattack, but instead attacked with a flute. There is no room for any answers to questions asked in anger.

Then why do you avoid it?

Because if you kill me now, Celia will collapse twice.

Those words made Kadan even more angry. When the battle between the two began, Celia could not get in between them. Kadan's sadness at seeing the bodies of his teachers and his desire to believe that his father was not the culprit were all real.

Gawain rang a silver bell with his last breath. The sound was slightly out of sync with Aeolus's flute. This meant that the flute heard during the attack was not a perfect replica, but was half a beat late.

Before he could say that, Gawain's hand fell. Kadan held the silver bell, but did not immediately understand its meaning. Aeolus retreated into the black fog, saying that if he fought any longer, the truth would disappear forever.

Celia did not follow Kadan. The first priority was to hold the funerals of teachers and rescue refugees. For the first time, the two people chose different paths in the face of the same grief.

Celia did not light the funeral fire all at once. The refugees were asked to tell each teacher what they remembered. Some people talked about the pot that Grimli fixed, and some people talked about the knot that Aila the Demon Hunter taught them. It was a funeral that did not reduce the death of a hero to a single battle scene.

Mistaken in the Fog



Kadan followed Aeolus and headed to the separate bell tower. It was the place Hercul and the seven pursuers promised eighteen years ago. Nine drinking tables were set up on the bell tower, and Hercul was waiting, emptying the glasses of his dead comrades.

Your teachers were planning to have you compete with Ignis here today. Hercul said. Not to see who is stronger, but to see what remains of the promise we started with.

Hercul even prepared a small scoreboard for the two of them. There was a note attached that Grimli was to be in charge of power, Aila the Demon Hunter would be in charge of judgment, and Kaze would be in charge of trickery. The last line had Robinyard written on it, saying that there was one point on the side that laughed during the fight.

Kadan announced the death of Ignis and placed a glass ember next to the empty glass. Hercul admitted that he treated his two children as if they were solutions to his resentment. Even good intentions can turn a person into a plan.

As Aeolus appeared beneath the bell tower, the Knights of the Star Sanctuary surrounded him. Death Knight Artus also sent evidence to Hercul that Aeolus killed their teachers. Kadan thought of the silver bell's off-beat beat, but was not sure.

Fog suddenly rolled in from the lake. People couldn't even recognize the face one step in front of them. The sounds of flutes, silver bells, and armor overlapped from all directions. When someone attacks, someone else's weapon returns.

Kadan saw Aeolus's shadow and rushed towards him. The moment the Dragon Breaker hit, the figure dissipated into black smoke. Death Knight Artus was an empty armor with the appearance of Aeolus.

The real Aeolus was blocking another clone from attacking Hercul. The two exchanged weapons several times, mistaking each other for enemies. When Celia stuck the green jade staff into the base of the bell tower, the wind rose upward and cleared away the fog.

Everyone, lower your weapons. Look at the choices, not the sounds!

Death Knight Artus's clone imitated a person's face and skills, but could not imitate the choice to protect someone. Whenever danger came, he looked for a figure that avoided himself, and the fake was revealed.

Instead of asking people for their names, Celia asked people to tell them the location of someone close to them. The fake read the memory and answered the name, but did not know which direction they ran to when someone was injured. Relationships were codes that were harder to replicate than information.

Kadan lowered his sword in front of Aeolus. Apologies didn't make the fight go away. Instead of saying he would forgive, Aeolus told him to reveal the death of his teachers until the end.

Death Knight Artus revealed its main body at the top of the bell tower. He absorbed some of the souls of the six teachers into his armor and used their skills. Grimli's hammer impact and Aila the Demon Hunter's arrow trajectory rained down on Kadan at the same time.

Kadan was unable to fight back. Breaking the teachers' movements felt like killing them twice. Celia slapped him.

The silver bells inside the shield shook. The masters' techniques produced different sounds, but when Death Knight Artus unfolded, they all ended in the same metallic sound. Kadan picked up the sword only after hearing that there

was a difference between remembering technology and remembering people.

Those are not teachers. Remember why they taught you.

Kadan closed his eyes and held up the silver bell. The clone of Death Knight Artus only had technology and no beats to fill in each other's gaps. He split the attack with binary splitting, revealing the soul storage core in the center of the armor.

Death Knight Artus abandoned the storage core and ran away. Six rays of light were released, circling the empty drinking table one at a time. The old glasses in the bell tower made a clear sound at the same time.

Kadan and Celia looked at each other, but did not immediately reconcile. I had to verbally deal with the hurt of not being believed and the choice to leave alone. They first filled the cups of the dead with alcohol.

Map of the Cross-Shaped Scar



There was a cross-shaped crack in the soul storage core that Death Knight Artus had abandoned. Celia found the same marks on his teachers' weapons. After making it look like he was dead with Aeolus's flute, the final wound was inflicted with the four-way blade of the soul sword.

The half beat of the silver bell left by Gawain also served as evidence. Death Knight Artus copied the technique and tone, but could not imitate the moment a living person changed the beat to match the other person's movements.

Kadan collected the surviving records and went to the garden where his teachers were buried. He knelt in front of Aeolus. Instead of asking for forgiveness, he said he had put his anger ahead of the truth.

Kadan also provided a record detailing the sequence of attacks he made and the injuries suffered by Aeolus. This was Celia's advice to not end the apology with emotion, but to leave it as a responsibility necessary for treatment and recovery.

Aeolus did not wake him up. I m not the only one who accepts your apology. Ask Celia too.

Celia held onto the fact that Kadan decided to grieve alone and left longer than the fact that Kadan did not trust him. Kadan did not try to explain right and wrong. We promised that next time we would not take away the opportunity to grieve together.

Their reconciliation did not end with just a hug. After finishing the funeral of our teachers, organizing the list of refugees, and rebuilding our broken house,

we continued to have awkward conversations for several days. The wound did not disappear, but it no longer changed shape in silence.

Kadan handed Celia a nail when he was fixing the roof, and Celia corrected a misspelling when Kadan wrote down his name. One day, after an argument, we slept in different tents, and the next day we returned to the same workstation. Long-lasting relationships are built on habits of returning rather than moments of reconciliation.

The movement path of Death Knight Artus also remained in the storage core. The four ends of the stigmata of the cross pointed to the Wildlands, Lighthaven Imperial Palace, Iron Palm Mountains, and Astra Peak. By connecting the four ley lines, he could infuse souls into an entire army of dead.

The first target was Wildland. Fenrir was already gathering troops to attack the capital of the Shadow Realm. Lucian was planning to instigate a war behind the scenes and engulf both sides with his spirit army after the two forces were exhausted.

Kadan had to return north. Celia said he would lead the Freeman's League and go together. Aeolus entrusted the reconstruction of the island to the residents' council and handed over the mobile core of the sound tower. It was a device that could connect distant units even on the battlefield.

Orihalcon asked me to take him too. This was because he felt guilty that the magnetic device that killed his teachers was of his own design. Instead of trying to atone with his life, Celia entrusted him with building a mobile barrier.

Orihalcon engraved his name in large letters on the first wall he built, but was told by Celia to erase it. Instead, he wrote down the names of both the blacksmith and the transport worker who created the device. The desire to be a hero never went away, but I started learning how to share the credit.

Before leaving, Kadan took silver bells from each of his teachers' weapons and placed them on the inside of his shield. Every time I walked, different sounds

collided, creating a clumsy harmony.

Griffon cavalry, led by Gilgamesh, was waiting at the southern gate. Titania said that his father was planning to appoint Kadan as Marshal of War.

Whose promise did you return this time?

Kadan looked at the northern grasslands. So that the people where I grew up don't become instruments of war.

Titania heard the answer and opened the way. A bow with a red string swayed in the north wind.

War of the Conqueror King



Fenrir treated Kadan like his own son. He united several tribes and was destroying the Northern Citadel of the Shadow Realm one by one. It was believed that decades of oppression could be ended if only the last capital was captured.

Kadan took the lead using the defensive tactics of the Ironforge strategic core. Before destroying the walls, he evacuated the inhabitants through underground waterways and froze the supply depot, forcing the garrison to surrender. The victory was slow, but fewer than half as many people died as in previous battles.

At the end of each battle, he wrote down the number of enemy and friendly wounded in the same ledger. Generals complained about the need to count the number of enemies. Kadan answered that it is not a ledger that calculates the strength to fight the next day, but a ledger that remembers the reasons why he could not stop today.

The generals of Fenrir were frustrated. He claimed that if he left his enemy alive, he would raise his sword again. Fenrir initially accepted Kadan's method, but as the war dragged on, he wanted a faster victory.

During the siege of the capital, Lucian chained the residents to the walls. He knew that Kadan would not be able to attack. Celia was a mobile sound tower that simultaneously sent messages to people in the city. It was a short instruction to hide in the cellar when the bell rang three times.

Titania's Griffon cavalry occupied the bell tower, and Gilgamesh opened the aqueduct gate. Kadan pulled out Death Knight Artus's soul army from the

front. When Ignis's spark was placed in the center of the shield, the dead souls inside the armor stopped moving for a moment.

The name of Ignis spread among the palace soldiers who saw the white light. Some called him a traitor, others called him the last prince. Kadan did not correct either. What the embers were doing now was not to determine a person's honor, but to give the trapped soul time to stop.

In the meantime, Celia spread the codex's liberation runes throughout the city. The lights trapped in each piece of armor emerged into the night sky. Death Knight Artus pulled in more souls to maintain its body, but instead lost its balance and retreated.

The capital has fallen. Fenrir offered to give Kadan the title of King of the North and territory in the South. Kadan declined. He asked that victory not be declared until the refugees returned.

That night, Celia discovered the second invasion map in Fenrir's military camp. The arrow did not stop at the Shadow Realm capital, but continued all the way to Lighthaven and the cities of the Free People's League. Fenrir believed that war would end only when all continents were unified under one law.

Kadan took the map and went to Fenrir. Weren't we fighting to prevent an invasion?

If you leave the weak kingdom as is, the next Lucian will emerge. I will make it one first.

Unification without protecting people is a war with a long name.

Fenrir was not angry. Rather, he said he would entrust the southern expeditionary force to Kadan. The logic was that damage could be reduced if it was taken over by someone they trusted. He also added a threat that if he refused, another general would attack him more brutally.

Kadan noticed that the logic was similar to what he had said in the past. Moments when you overcame the opposition of someone close to you because something worse would happen if you didn't save them. The saying that invasion is less bad when a good person leads it was a cloth covering the invasion itself.

Kadan avoided giving a direct answer. Outside the military camp, Elwin was treating northerners. Fenrir knew that Kadan could not leave his mother and hometown behind.

Celia bought time for evacuation by changing the orders in the military camp one by one, as if playing hide and seek. But I couldn't fake it for long. Fenrir's SS began arresting Freeman's League liaison soldiers.

On the day the war was won, Kadan had to find a way to escape again from the country where he grew up.

Three Silk Seals



Hercul arrived at the Wildland military camp. He disguised himself as an envoy congratulating Fenrir's victory, but in reality he came to deliver the three seals left behind by Kadan's teachers. Grimli and Gawain each left one seal before their deaths, and the last one was Hercul's own.

The first seal contained a method to neutralize the southern invasion route of the Ironforge strategic core. Instead of bursting a river or collapsing a castle, the plan was to shift the date of the supply rune by one day and the large army would stop on its own. Kaze was a unique trick.

In the corner of the note, there was a joke written by Kaze that heroes fall most easily in front of food tables. Kadan choked up while trying to laugh. The voice of the dead teacher came back more clearly in one crooked line than in a grand will.

The second seal displayed a list of Fenrir's close associates and the generals who had been bribed by Lucian. Aila the Demon Hunter has been tracking the Black Arrow within the northern camp for a long time. Fenrir's desire to conquer was his, but the hand that rushed the southern expedition was Lucian.

The list also included the names of generals who were not purchased. Aila the Demon Hunter knew that if suspicion was only spread, the army would collapse on its own. Establishing who you can trust was as important as finding the traitor.

The third seal was empty. Hercul asked Kadan to choose what to write directly. The reason the teachers did not leave the correct answer was because if they replaced the last choice, they would once again be making the child an

instrument of promise.

Kadan wrote two sentences on the third silk. Does not participate in the southern expedition. I leave with my mother. He wrote down his name and delivered it directly to Fenrir.

After reading the silk, Fenrir made Elwin stay in the military tent. It was under the pretext of protecting guests, but in reality, they were hostages. He told Kadan that he would send his mother home if he became the vanguard of the southern expedition.

Titania pointed the knife at his father. You gave me as a treasure, but now you use my mother as a chain?

Fenrir imprisoned his daughter. Gilgamesh was stripped of his military authority while trying to free his sister. The Conqueror, who was trying to unite his family, was making enemies of those closest to him.

Celia proposed a plan to Kadan to secretly steal Elwin. Kadan hesitated whether the expeditionary force should set off while rescuing his mother. Elwin heard the conversation between the two and called his son.

Your father gave up his life to send me. I am grateful for that choice, but I have also been trapped in that day for the rest of my life. If you abandon so many people just because you saved me, I end up paying for someone else's life.

Elwin added his own emblem to the back of the third seal. I do not buy my son's judgment with my life.

That night, Hercul, Celia, Titania, and Gilgamesh shared roles. It was decided to change the supply rune, notify the southern tribes of the invasion, and open Elwin's detention barracks. Kadan attended Fenrir's meeting and wasted time.

The plan was almost successful, but the buyer of Lucian discovered Elwin. He put a knife to his mother's throat to force Kadan into submission. Elwin

trembled with fear but held onto the blade himself.

Kadan, don't make your decision based on me. Look at the people you said you would protect.

She pulled the soldier's sword to her chest. When Kadan came running, Elwin was already in Celia's arms. Finally, he stroked his son's face and thanked him for being the one who chose truth over revenge.

Kadan tried to freeze the wound, but Elwin blocked his hand. He told me not to use my remaining strength on myself, but to freeze the alarm tower to give myself time to escape. Kadan did not want to accept the last request as a tactic, but Celia turned his hand towards the alarm tower.

While ice covered the tower, Elwin thanked Titania for taking care of his son in the north, and asked Celia to always tell Kadan when he was wrong in the future. It was not a way to choose a woman to stay by his son's side, but a farewell that respected both people's choices.

The military camp alarm went off. Kadan didn't even get time to hug her mother and cry. He had to escape to the south with the three seals in his arms.

The World Worth Protecting



Kadan The party neutralized the supply rune and exited Wildland. The expeditionary force set out but stopped at the border, heading to different rendezvous points for food carts and mana fuel. It was three days that saved tens of thousands of lives.

Elwin was buried on a hill overlooking the North Star. Kadan untied the red string from his father's dagger and tied it to the tombstone. Titania made a knot alongside the string that was returned a long time ago. Celia was by Kadan's side throughout the funeral, but did not cry or speak on his behalf.

After the funeral, Kadan cried out loud in front of Celia for the first time. It was a cry that I endured even when my teachers died. Celia didn't say it would be okay and just sat in the same spot while his back was shaking.

Death Knight Artus and Lucian headed to Astra Peak, where the last ley line gathered. By connecting the four points and awakening the spirit army, it was possible to wipe out the stopped expeditionary force and the southern city all at once.

At the top of the mountain was an old dueling arena. Aeolus, Leonar, Aqualord, who lost their power, and Gandar all went their separate ways. They were once greats who competed against the strongest on the continent, but no one said their rankings. What mattered now was not the strength of one person.

Lucian inserted the last piece of the Ironforge strategic core into the ley device. Death Knight Artus drew thousands of souls into his armor and swelled into a gigantic black knight. He sequentially copied Aeolus's flute, Leonar's seal, and Hercul's protective circle.

The masters were pushed aside by their own skills. The clones were bigger and faster, but I didn't know why the technology was created. Aeolus's sound only caused one to get lost, Leonar's seal only destroyed it, and Hercul's shield only covered its own body.

When Leonar saw his seal shattering a mountain, he remembered how he had once boasted of its power. Aeolus heard that the sound of the flute was only used to break people's hearts. Each has seen in the enemy what his skills have been like when they have gone awry.

Kadan and Celia delved into the differences. When Kadan was shocked in front of people, Celia released its power into the empty sky. Gandar mixed Death Knight Artus's left and right commands, and Aqualord called out the name of the trapped soul with the remaining life mana.

Lucian tried to run away but was caught by Death Knight Artus. The more souls it consumed, the more the armor forgot whose orders it was following, and even saw its creator as fuel. Lucian cried out to Kadan to save him.

Kadan moved to save him. Celia was surprised but did not stop. This time, Kadan also asked her judgment.

If you save me, I ll betray you again. Celia said. Still, I don t want to let that armor decide who to eat.

Together, the two took out Lucian. However, as soon as Lucian was free, it activated the ley line device. Ignis's artificial flame spread down the mountain.

Kadan felt the shame that he was wrong rise before the anger of being betrayed. Celia shouted, Regret now, later, and turned the direction of the flames. Because we made the decision together, the responsibility for failure was not placed on just one person.

Kadan placed a glass ember in the center of the device. The life mana that Ignis sent back at the end resonated with the replica flame. Ignis's voice was not heard through the flames. However, the final choice to return what was taken

was repeated once again.

The ley line device was reversed and the trapped souls were released. Death Knight Artus's armor collapsed into empty steel plates, and Lucian was bound by the control runes he had created. Kadan did not kill him, but handed him over to the Freeman's League for trial.

Astra Bong masters gave different answers to Gandar's question about who was the strongest. Kadan did not reply. I knew that even at the moment when I had the strongest technique, I would not have been able to stop the ley line device if I were alone.

A Wildland messenger arrived from below the mountain. There was news that Fenrir had halted the southern expedition, and that old wounds from the battlefield were worsening and that Kadan was being called for the last time.

One Who Is Not Called a Hero



When Kadan and Celia returned to Wildland, the first snow was falling on the grasslands. The Conqueror's huge tent had been pulled down, and Fenrir was lying in the small tent that Kadan had frequented as a child.

Titania and Gilgamesh stayed by their father's side. The southern expedition had stopped, but the empire founded by Fenrir was already shaken by the succession struggle. His final orders were to send refugees from occupied territories back to their homes and for each tribe to hold a new council.

The land I acquired all my life was scattered in a matter of days. Fenrir laughed. Do you think I failed?

Kadan did not give an easy answer. Fenrir bound together the tribes that were killing each other and ended the oppression of the Shadow Realm. At the same time, they tried to take away other people's hometowns for greater unification. Two truths existed together in one person.

You have saved many lives, and you have placed many in fear. One cannot erase the other.

Fenrir seemed not to like the answer, closed his eyes and asked again. Then what is a hero? If it is not the person who acquired the largest land or the person who defeated the strongest enemy.

Kadan looked outside the tent. Celia was recording the names of war orphans, and Titania was distributing food to soldiers who were about to be dispersed going home. Gilgamesh sent away the generals who wanted to erect a statue of his father.

I think he is a person who uses his own power to expand the space for others to live in. Even if his name remains, that space remains.

Fenrir laughed for a while and then coughed. Then I'd be half hero and half disaster.

A person does not end with one name.

Fenrir asked Kadan to write his biography honestly. He burned the royal officer's scroll that recorded only his victories, and asked him to leave behind the tribes he killed and the promises he broke. Titania said he would take charge of the record.

The Conqueror died that night. I didn't look for the crown until the end, and took Titania's and Gilgamesh's hands on one side each. Instead of a fancy grave, the funeral was held in a small pile of stones in the middle of a meadow.

Kadan rejected the generals' requests to take the throne. Celia also rejected a proposal to transform the Freeman's League into a kingdom. The two entrusted the Ironforge strategic core to archives in several cities, and the Nine Shadows Codex separated healing records and forbidden arts so that anyone could monitor them.

Ignis's glass ember returned all of its power from the Astra Rod, leaving only a transparent piece behind. Kadan buried it between the graves of Balian and Ysela. While not disobeying Ignis's last request that he would not lie down next to his parents because he did not qualify, I wanted to leave a place for him to return to if he got lost.

The wooden horse was also buried together. This time, one wheel turned fine. Kadan did not engrave the words "prince" or "traitor" on the tombstone, but wrote only one name. Ignis. I hoped he would not be reduced to one evaluation in the end.

Celia entrusted the reconstruction of Baram Island to the residents' council. Aeolus remained a recorder to advise the council when called, rather than a

monarch to command. For the first time, he asked his daughter where she was going and did not tell her when she would return.

The two men rebuilt the tavern in Elwin village. The customers who opened on the first day were Hercul, Gandar, Naiad, and Aqualord. On the empty table, the teachers of Kadan and the glasses of Ignis and Elwin were placed. No one cleaned the cup away.

Kadan hung the first sentence of the Ironforge strategy core on the tavern wall. Count those who survive before you win. Celia added small text below it. And ask those people what they want.

As the night fell, Gandar tried to steal an empty glass and drink, but was hit on the back of the hand by Naiad. Aqualord stirred the soup pot with his weak hands, and Hercul hung the door upside down and took it off again. The characters in the legend lived in their new home, making not-so-great mistakes.

At dawn, Kadan and Celia loaded Pegasus. There was more than one place to protect, and the end of the war did not mean the end of the wounds. News from the Northern Refugee Camp had arrived from the Free People's League.

Do you have a plan to not break down the door this time? Celia asked.

Kadan thought for a moment. Ask first at the door.

There has been progress.

After the two people left the snow, the silver bells on the eaves of the tavern rang. There were no trumpets calling the names of heroes or royal processions. However, each path they passed left one door for people to choose for themselves.

That's how the first story of Noon Hero ended. The snow covered the footprints, but did not cover the road.